

FULL OF GRACE

Written by

Shane O'Connor

OVER BLACK:

The sound of wind blowing through an autumn forest. Several footfalls grow near, quick and rhythmic like trotting horses.

Then a burst of young female laughter.

FADE IN:

EXT. RURAL ROAD - AFTERNOON

SUPER: DOVER, NEW HAMPSHIRE

A chilly, sunny afternoon along a dirt road. Late November. The trees, with what little leaves they still hold, create dappled light all over.

ROADSIDE. Tall weeds. A GRASS SNAKE pokes its head out. Feels the world with its tongue. It senses something, then disappears.

Suddenly, THREE GIRLS (pre-teens) gallop briskly up the road, their ponytails bouncing, legs trotting like horses.

The girls are riding HOBBYHORSES -- stuffed, fabric-wrapped horse heads fastened to the end of broomsticks.

EXT. WOODED TRAIL - MOMENTS LATER

The girls gallop up to a wooded trail that cuts into the forest. They stop at the trail's entry.

One of the girls, KRISTA, 11, blonde and a bit chubby, fixes her attention to the dark wooded trail. She's unsure.

KRISTA

We're going in there?

BETH (12), tall, skinny, tomboyish, rolls her eyes at Krista.

BETH

It's this way to the river, or else
we go all the way around. For like
an hour.

HOLLY (12), sweet face and very pretty, pats the neck of her hobbyhorse, a white Arabian stallion.

HOLLY

Our horses are thirsty, remember?
We hafta get 'em to water soon.

Krista runs her fingers through the black yarn of her hobbyhorse's mane, gently, as if to comfort it.

KRISTA
(re: her hobbyhorse)
Bella gets spooked on trails. She
likes open spaces better.

BETH
Well, Bella's gonna have to learn.

Holly produces an apple from her pocket. Gives it to Krista.

HOLLY
Here. This'll calm Bella down.

Krista takes the apple. She smiles. She role-plays feeding the apple to Bella.

HOLLY (CONT'D)
Last one to the river mucks all our
stalls for a week!

Holly suddenly breaks into a gallop down the wooded trail, leaving Beth and Krista in the dust.

BETH
Hey! Not fair!

Beth and Krista square their shoulders, grab their horse's reins and stride off after Holly.

KRISTA
Holly! You have to canter!

EXT. WOODED TRAIL - AFTERNOON

The girls racing playfully through the forest on their "horses", hopping over logs and rocks.

Beth goes to pass Holly, but Holly easily out maneuvers her.

The girls giggle and squeal. Holly pulls away from Beth.

BETH
Holly, you bitch!

EXT. WOODED TRAIL - MOMENTS LATER

Holly, well ahead of the others now, gallops straight into...

EXT. SMALL CLEARING - CONTINUOUS

A small clearing. Holly appears, pauses. Catches her breath. She looks around...

She's actually entered into a cemetery. Historic. Puritan New England. Headstones from the 1600's.

Holly glances back at the trail she left behind. She smiles mischievously.

KRISTA (O.S.)
(distant)
Holly?

Holly runs up to a mossy headstone and ducks behind it. She lets out a quiet laugh.

A moment... The wind blows. Fallen leaves spray across the cemetery.

Suddenly, a branch SNAPS, heavily on the other side of the cemetery. Holly spins and looks to the source, to the far side of the cemetery, into the dark forest.

Her mischief falls from her face, as we stay on her, unable to see the danger that she sees.

BETH (O.S.)
(closer)
Holly?

Holly turns back and peeks around the headstone at Beth and Krista arriving at the edge of the clearing.

WITH BETH AND KRISTA

KRISTA
Why does she always do this?

BETH
Cuz she's weird. She's probably
already at the river. C'mon.

Beth and Krista trot off down the trail.

WITH HOLLY

Watching her friends disappear. She looks back again at the far side of the cemetery... Nothing but trees now.

Finally, she gets up and gallops away -- not toward her friends, and not toward whatever she saw on the far side of the cemetery, but decidedly somewhere in between.

EXT. RIVERBANK - LATER

Muddy banks of the river. Tall grasses. Logs and rocks. The sun hangs low as tall, cold shadows cloak the riverbank.

Krista sits on a log, dabbing away a spot of river water from her horse's mouth with her coat sleeve.

Further down shore, Beth tries to skip stones across the water. She gives up and walks over to Krista and sits down.

BETH

It's been twenty minutes. I'm calling her.

Beth takes out her cell, begins to dial.

KRISTA

So, does this mean we win?

BETH

No. It means I win, moron. I got here first.

Krista frowns. Beth hangs up her phone, unable to reach Holly. She begins to tap out a text --

BETH (CONT'D)

Where r-u you dumb... little... sh-

A SCREAM. A girl's scream. Holly. Distant and cut-off suddenly as if by force.

The girls spin and look into the woods, chilled by the terror of the sound.

EXT. WOODS - MOMENTS LATER

Beth running through the woods.

BETH

Holly?!

KRISTA (O.S.)

Beth!

EXT. STONE FOUNDATION - MOMENTS LATER

Ancient stone foundation overgrown with brush, grass. Once a house, now a remnant of New Hampshire's earliest settlers.

Krista is here, standing at the edge of the foundation, full of fear and confusion. Beth runs up to her, out of breath.

BETH

What is it?

Krista points at the foundation. Beth looks down at...

The foundation's grassy floor, and laying there within it, squared off by the stones of over 350 years of early American history...

Holly's white Arabian hobbyhorse.

EXT. TOWN OF DOVER - NIGHT

Small town Dover. The night lit up by a full moon shimmering the Cocheco River that cuts through the town.

ADULT MALE (V.O.)

Lemme get this straight: three of you's went into the park, but only the two of ya's came out?

EXT. RESIDENTIAL HOME - NIGHT

Bungalow. Quiet sub-division. Two POLICE CARS parked out front. Inside the home all the lights are on.

Hear the sobs of Beth and Krista.

BETH (V.O.)

Dad! That's all we know! She just... disappeared.

KRISTA (V.O.)

Then we heard her screaming. And then we found her horse.

ADULT MALE

How could she just vanish? She say she was going somewhere?

BETH (V.O.)

No! We were just --

(sobs)

I don't know where she is!

ADULT MALE (V.O.)

But you're okay? Nobody's hurt?

More sobs. And as we FADE TO BLACK...

ADULT FEMALE (V.O.)
Girls, just tell the officers what
happened. Okay? Can you do that?

ADULT MALE (V.O.)
Wait. Has anyone called the mother?

FADE IN:

EXT. GOOD TIMES TAVERN - LOS ANGELES - MORNING

A dreary-looking tavern near the airport in Inglewood.
Security bars guard the heavily tinted windows.

INT. GOOD TIMES TAVERN - CONTINUOUS

Not any less dreary inside. A few drunk unsavories at the
bar, half-watching a college football game on the big-screen.

Cheap Thanksgiving decor has been placed around the bar --
images of cornucopias, cartoonish turkeys. It's the effort
that counts.

From somewhere in back sound the digital bleeps and melodies
of a video poker machine.

AT POKER MACHINE

DETECTIVE JOHN KIERSTEAD, 41, sits on a barstool, burning
cigarette in his hand as he taps away at the cards on the
screen. He's lean and attractive, seems calm, but with eyes
always tense, anticipating.

The machine sings as John wins a big hand. He barely reacts.

BARTENDER comes by with a shot of bourbon. He sets the shot
down next to John.

BARTENDER
Here ya are.

JOHN
(eyes on the screen)
Thanks, Freddy.

John bets big again. Loses. Sighs. Looks over at the shot of
bourbon for a long moment. He finally reaches for it just as--

His pager buzzes at his hip. He peeks down, studies it.

He springs off the stool and downs his shot and grabs his coat and heads for the door. He tosses a wad of wrinkled bills onto the bar on his way out.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Happy Thanksgivin', Freddy.

John exits. Bartender picks up the bills, counts them out. He stops -- an angered expression of being short-changed.

BARTENDER
Fucker.

EXT. EAST LOS ANGELES - MORNING

Two-storey apartment complex on the corner. The circus is already here -- EMS. Fire. Uniformed cops and some news vans.

An unmarked rolls up and stops. John gets out of it. He fires up a cigarette. He casts a wide look across the scene.

A uniformed hurries past us with a roll of yellow crime tape. The ribbon unfurling behind him, tied to something unseen, separating John from the crime scene. John stops the officer.

JOHN
Whaddya we got?

The officer winds the tape around a sign pole, cordons off the area.

OFFICER
Two on the lawn, three more inside.
(pause, grim)
One of 'em just a kid.

John glances over at the house.

JOHN
Shit.

On the grass-barren front lawn lay two dead bodies -- man and woman, 30's, gunshots through the head. Blood all over. Two lawn chairs upended close by.

OFFICER (O.S.)
Like they never saw it comin'.

Visuals of the neighborhood: homeowners on their stoops, on-lookers in their cars. Everyone watches, on edge, but nobody talks.

OFFICER (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Streets are blind as usual. Buncha
amnesiacs.

BACK TO JOHN

JOHN
See no evil, hear no evil, and you
will survive.

He dips under the tape and makes his way up to the house.
Suddenly a hand grips his shoulder, stops him. John turns,
sees--

SARGE
I already got a team in there.

SARGE, 50's, large and in charge, keeps his hand on John's
shoulder as he leads him away from the crime scene.

SARGE (CONT'D)
I need you to head out and canvass
the neighborhood.

John looks away, annoyed.

SARGE (CONT'D)
You got a problem with that?

JOHN
Nah.

SARGE
Look, John.

John keeps his focus on the house behind Sarge where Coroners
carry out a bodybag. A small one. Kid-sized.

SARGE (CONT'D)
John. Look at me. Hey.

John looks at Sarge.

SARGE (CONT'D)
You took a few months off. You did
what you had to do. And believe me
when I say that everybody here is
super proud of your decision.

John shifts his weight, impatient, and feeling patronized.

SARGE (CONT'D)
But there is no way I'm letting you
in there.

JOHN
Not like I'm a rookie.

Another detective walks by. DET. MCAVOY, Latino, very fat. He carries a tray of coffee and donuts for the team.

DET. MCAVOY
Welcome back, Kierstead. Little late to the party, huh? You avoid the liquor stores and take the long way around?

Det. McAvoy laughs.

JOHN
Nah, too busy turkey-basting your fat-ass whore of a mother.

Det. McAvoy flips John the finger.

DET. MCAVOY
Fuck you, Kierstead. You and your fucking attitude.

JOHN
Oh, yeah?

DET. MCAVOY
Yeah. I hope you fuckin' relapse. You know that?

John whips out a mickey of whiskey from his coat pocket. Shakes it at McAvoy.

JOHN
Way ahead of ya, ya fat fuck!

The two men begin shouting insults at each other. Sarge stops the dispute quickly and with AUTHORITY.

SARGE
McAvoy! Outta here! Now!

McAvoy, eyeing John, shakes his head and leaves.

DET. MCAVOY
Asshole.

John thrusts the finger at McAvoy.

SARGE
(to John)
This is what I'm talking about.

JOHN

C'mon, you letting fat-ass McAvoy in there? Jesus, a fucking cream-puff's more competent than him, and you know it! Just lemme inside. Lemme do my job.

SARGE

Not happening! You gotta work your way back up to that. That was the deal -- prove to us you deserve to be back in there. Until then, you're door-to-door.

John's pissed. A moment passes.

SARGE (CONT'D)

Got that?

A woman's WAIL behind Sarge breaks the moment. It's the family. They've arrived on scene. The woman screams again, inconsolable grief. She collapses to the ground.

Sarge, unfazed, stays on John.

SARGE (CONT'D)

Do you understand me, John?

INT. JOHN'S UNMARKED - MOMENTS LATER

John behind the wheel of his unmarked. He turns down a residential road, pulls over, and shuts off his car.

He glances across the road at a shoddy ball field where a group of neighborhood boys play baseball. He sits and watches the boys play. A few moments pass. He gets out of his car.

EXT. RESIDENTIAL NEIGHBORHOOD - CONTINUOUS

John sparks a cigarette and starts to walk the beat. The crack of a baseball bat is heard. Well-hit ball. The boys all cheer, until...

CRASH! John pauses. Mid-smoke. He slowly turns...

Fuck. His car. Windshield obliterated by the homerun ball.

He glances across at the ball field. It's empty. The chain-link gate at the field's far end swings shut with a clank.

EXT. LANEWAY - MOMENTS LATER

John walks a residential laneway, holding in his hand the baseball that broke his windshield.

CLOSE on: the BASEBALL, as John starts to turn it over in his hand, cycling through grips, pitch selections -- fastball, curveball, cutter. A nasty slider. Then a knuckleball grip.

His cycles are rapid and well-rehearsed, like he's done them ten thousand times before.

EXT. GARAGE - LANEWAY - CONTINUOUS

A garage. Its door pulled almost shut. Almost. The heel of a baseball glove sits exposed under the door. A boy's whisper:

BOY
Dude! Your glove!

ANOTHER BOY
(whisper)
... Shit!

The glove is quickly yanked back and disappears. More hushed voices as the boys begin to argue with each other.

John approaches the garage. Stops. The boys arguing stops. John throws open the garage door to...

THE BOYS. Half-dozen of them. Some of them look scared shitless. Others try to hide their shitless fear.

John has one hand gripping the baseball, the other on his hip pulling back his coat, showing a badge and gun. He holds up the ball.

JOHN
Who hit this?

Hesitation from the group. Then one of them, a BLACK KID, 12, big for his age, hardens up--

BLACK KID
I did.

JOHN
Oh yeah?

BLACK KID
Yeah. Can't bust a kid for goin' yard.

JOHN
Who's the pitcher?

A shy, skinny LATINO KID, 11, doesn't move, not a peep, eyes to the floor. The rest of the boys turn and look at him. Finally, the pitcher looks up and raises his hand, meekly.

LATINO KID
... Me.

JOHN
What do you guys know about that house down on East Olympic, by the 7-Eleven?

BLACK KID
Heard a whole family got iced.

JOHN
That's right. Including a three year-old girl.

John checks their body language: at least one kid looks like he might know something. The pitcher. John senses it.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Alright, let's go. Everybody back on the field.

The boys look to one another, confused.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Let's go! C'mon, move it!

EXT. BASEBALL FIELD - MOMENTS LATER

The boys and John walk onto the field.

JOHN
Pitcher, come with me. Slugger, you're up.

PITCHER'S MOUND

John and the Latino Kid on the mound together. Black Kid steps up to the plate, eager, cocky.

BLACK KID
Pitch it in!

JOHN
Hey! Chill out, will ya?
(to Latino Kid)
(MORE)

JOHN (CONT'D)

Now, you're a lefty. That's a right-handed hitter. What pitch did you throw him when he crushed it into my windshield?

LATINO KID

(shrugs)

I just threw it as hard as I could?

John hands the ball to the kid, and steps back.

JOHN

Do it again.

(to Black Kid)

You ready?

BLACK KID

I was born ready.

John nods at Latino Kid, who throws the ball as hard as he can. Black Kid swings. CRACK! The ball soars, high and long and over the fence. Another mammoth dinger.

Latino Kid sighs, looks down, deflated. Black Kid grows more cocky. Bat flip. Spreads out his arms, puffs out his chest. Taunting--

BLACK KID (CONT'D)

Big Papi! Big Papi! You can't touch me! Chicks dig the long ball! Come and get it. You can't touch me!

The ball is fetched, thrown back to John who steps back onto the mound with Latino Kid.

JOHN

How about I teach you a pitch that Mr. All-Star here won't ever be able to hit?

LATINO KID

Sure!

JOHN

Okay. But here's the deal: I teach you this pitch, and if he can't hit it, you tell me everything you know about that house down on Olympic. But if he does hit it, you don't gotta say a word to me, and I walk away. Deal?

Latino Kid, wary, mulls this over. Finally, he nods 'yes'.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Great. This time throw a changeup.
Four-seamer. It's gonna look like a
fastball, but the speed will
change, and it'll throw his timing
off and his balance off. And he
won't be able to hit it. Ever.

Latino Kid smiles at that possibility.

JOHN (CONT'D)
So here's your grip...

John demonstrates by palming the baseball across all four
seams, tucking his thumb and pointer finger under the ball.

JOHN (CONT'D)
See? Now you do it.
(hands Latino Kid the
ball)
Tuck your thumb and finger
together, like a circle.
(Latino Kid does it)
That's it. Now, when you release
the ball, keep your back leg solid,
don't be jumping off too much.
This'll control the speed of the
pitch and it'll fool him into
thinking it's a fastball.

LATINO KID
How hard do I throw it?

JOHN
As hard as you can.

BLACK KID (O.S.)
C'mon! Throw it already!

John steps off the mound. The kid gets into his stance. He
grips the ball for the changeup. He winds up and releases the
ball as hard as he can down the plate.

Black Kid swings mightily. Misses. Latino Kid, almost in
disbelief, smiles back at John, who nods.

JOHN
Nice pitch. Now do it again.

Ball is thrown back. Latino Kid repeats the grip, the stance.
He releases the ball. Black Kid swings through it.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Yes. Again.

Once more: grip, stance, release. Strike three, he's out.

The rest of the boys clap and cheer. Black Kid stares down Latino Kid. He throws his bat and walks away frustrated.

LATINO KID

(to John)

How'd you know how to do that?

John takes the ball. Studies it. A moment passes. He smiles.

JOHN

My dad taught me that pitch... long time ago.

John seems lost in "long time ago". He snaps to.

JOHN (CONT'D)

So what do you know 'bout that house?

LATINO KID

I dunno shit, mister.

The kid gives John a hard look and walks off the mound. John got played by a 12-year old. Damn.

EXT. LOS ANGELES - DAY TO NIGHT

TIME LAPSE: the sun sets, night falls over the city.

INT. JOHN'S CAR (DRIVING) - NIGHT

John behind the wheel, looking tired.

INT. CONVENIENCE STORE - NIGHT

John at the cash paying for cigs, snacks, and booze.

John exits the store.

EXT. CHEAP MOTEL - NIGHT

Young black woman, ANGIE, 20's, in a skin-tight dress, stands outside a motel room door. A set of headlights sweep across her as John's car pulls up, shuts off. John gets out.

ANGIE

Baby John.

JOHN

Ang.

John comes up to Angie, digs out some cash, peels off a few bills. She takes it and tucks it away in her purse. John unlocks the motel door, and the two step inside.

INT. CHEAP MOTEL ROOM - LATER

Sex. Angie is bent over the mini-bar as John gives it to her. Rough. The little bottles inside the fridge clank away.

The TV in the room is tuned to the Weather Network. A sexy weather woman announces a late November L.A. heat wave.

MOMENTS LATER

Angie off in the bathroom, cleaning herself up. John pours out two cups of whiskey.

JOHN

Wanna stay a while?

ANGIE

I can't.

Angie appears out of the bathroom, dressed to leave. John flashes her more money.

ANGIE (CONT'D)

Still ain't sleeping, huh? You know they got pills for that?

John pushes.

JOHN

Just until the sun comes up?

Pause.

ANGIE

Shit, it's your money.

She takes the money.

LATER

Angie sitting by the TV tuned to a sitcom. She laughs at the show. She does a line of cocaine.

She takes a drink of John's whiskey, looks across at John sound asleep in the bed. Snoring. Loudly.

Angie turns up the TV to drown out John. She does more coke. She laughs at the TV.

INT. CHEAP MOTEL ROOM - MORNING

Morning. John's cell phone on the night stand. It buzzes. Call display: **TRUDY**.

John stirs, wakes up. He looks at his phone. He answers it.

JOHN
Trudy..? Huh..?
(sits up)
What? What about him?

EXT. CHEAP MOTEL - MOMENTS LATER

Door swings opens. A concerned-looking John steps out. It's dawn and already the L.A. freeway is heavy with traffic.

JOHN
Well, how did it happen..? Oh...
Ok... yeah. But what am I--

Trudy on the other line. Heavy sobs. We hear her pleas--

TRUDY (ON PHONE)
Just come home, John... Please.

A TAXI pulls up. Driver honks the horn.

JOHN
I mean what am I supposed to...
Look, if I can get time off work,
then yes--

TRUDY (ON PHONE)
John! Please.

JOHN
I know! Fuck. Okay. Jesus Christ,
Trudy.
(lights a cigarette)
I wouldn't be able to stay long. A
couple days at the most.

TRUDY (ON PHONE)
Just come home?

More honking. Angie steps out, ready to go. John, upset, hangs up the phone. Angie looks to him.

ANGIE
Y'kay, baby?

A beat.

JOHN
My father died.

ANGIE
Oh... bummer. Well, I mean... that
sucks.

She grows uncomfortable. Compassion isn't her strong suit.

ANGIE (CONT'D)
Hey. I'll see you around, okay?

John doesn't respond. Angie departs into the taxi. The taxi pulls away, leaving John alone, staring off into the freeway traffic.

INT. DASH 8 AIRPLANE - DAY

The loud BUZZ of turbo prop engines. POV of a small window. Through it stretches an expanse of hilly New England countryside. Its endless trees explode with autumn colors.

John is seated at the window. He looks out and down at the landscape. The November sun catches his face.

He pulls back. Looks around. He's one of only a few passengers on the plane. He gets out of his seat.

INT. DASH 8 - BATHROOM - MOMENTS LATER

John against the wall in the tight bathroom smoking a cigarette. A "No Smoking" placard displayed just next to him.

EXT. DOVER, NEW HAMPSHIRE - DAY

A group of destitute MEN line up at a MOBILE SOUP KITCHEN serving up hot soup and crackers and bottled water.

INT. MOBILE SOUP KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

TRUDY KIERSTEAD, early 30's, petite, short hair. Pious looking with a small cross around her neck. She spoons out soup from the big pot and into bowls for the men.

She offers faith-based words of encouragement to each man--

TRUDY

God praise. Lord be with you.

Trudy hands a bowl to the next man in line. A look of recognition on her face.

TRUDY (CONT'D)

Lord have mercy. Jesus loves you.

The man's face goes unseen to us, as he sheepishly takes the bowl of soup, turns, and walks off.

Trudy watches after the man for a beat.

INT. DASH 8 - LATER

Out the plane's window as the landing gear uncoils from under the wing and locks into place. In the distance lies the town of Dover, New Hampshire.

John shifts uncomfortably in his seat.

INT. DOVER AIRPORT - MOMENTS LATER

Small regional airport. A gathering of people crowd the arrival gate, waiting anxiously for their loved ones. Among them is Trudy.

She watches as passengers disembark the small jet. She checks her phone. Fixes her hair. Excited. Nervous.

She spots John step off the plane. She brightens, grows with excitement, as John crosses the tarmac and in through the arrival doors.

She waves at him. Their eyes lock. They smile. Trudy practically bursts through the crowd, throwing her arms around John. Big hug. Buries herself into him.

TRUDY

John. Oh! Praise God.

JOHN

Hey, Tru.

She holds on. Her smile slowly fades. John's fades, too.

INT. DOVER AIRPORT - MOMENTS LATER

The luggage carousel. John waits for his baggage to arrive. Trudy stands next to him. She peeks up at her big brother, studying him without him noticing.

INT. TRUDY'S CAR - LATER

Trudy drives. John has his window rolled down. He looks out at the Dover sights and sounds. He grows agitated.

JOHN

You still, uh, seeing whatshisname?

TRUDY

Doug.

JOHN

Yeah.

TRUDY

Yes.

JOHN

Good... That's good.

TRUDY

He, um, well... we live together now.

JOHN

Got your own place?

TRUDY

Not exactly. Doug moved in.

JOHN

He moved in? Into the house?

TRUDY

Yeah. It's serious now, John. You know? In a good way. A very good way. We're still tryin' for kids, but... Maybe it's just not in God's plan, right?

JOHN

Right.

TRUDY

I think dad liked having another cop around. Someone to talk to. Cop stuff? You know?

John looks to Trudy.

TRUDY (CONT'D)
The financial's alone, John. I mean, we split everything fifty-fifty, and--

JOHN
Trudy. It's fine.

They drive in silence for a while. They cross the bridge that spans the Cocheco River and into downtown Dover. Suddenly, Trudy, like she just remembered something big--

TRUDY
Shit! You must be starving. Hey, let's do Angelo's!

JOHN
You know, I can't even remember the last time I had Angelo's.

INT. TRUDY'S CAR - LATER

John in the car parked outside Angelo's Pizza on Main Street. Trudy can be seen inside the pizza shop, ordering.

It's around midday. On the street there's a fair bit of activity. A few passing folks seem to recognize John.

EXT. TRUDY'S CAR - CONTINUOUS

Two TEEN BOYS on bikes pass by, slowly. They stop.

TEEN BOY #1
(hushed tone to other teen)
Hey, I think that's John Kierstead.

TEEN BOY #2
The baseball player?

TEEN BOY #1
My dad told me he saw him throw a rock straight across Salmon Falls River. The big part.

TEEN BOY #2
No way. That's like 300 feet.

TEEN BOY #1
Says he saw him do it. Launched it
clear into the State of Maine.

INT. TRUDY'S CAR - CONTINUOUS

John, feeling self-conscious, sinks a bit in his seat. The
teens approach the car.

TEEN BOY #1
Hey, mister. Aren't you--

VOICE (O.S.)
Johnny? Johnny Kierstead?

John, startled, turns to see framed in the driver window an
OLDER MAN, 70's, camo jacket, dirty Budweiser hat.

OLDER MAN
Yessir! I thought I recognized ya.
I used to fish with your dad.

John draws a blank. And he also doesn't give a shit.

OLDER MAN (CONT'D)
But then again, everybody fished
with Mackie.
(thrusts a hand out)
I'm Frank. Frank Cisco.

JOHN
Oh, uh, hi.

John shakes the man's hand.

FRANK
Sorry about your dad. Too soon. He
was a great man. Helluva cop.

John just nods. He fires up smoke.

FRANK (CONT'D)
Say, didja ever get back into
playin' ball at all?

JOHN
No.

John eyeballs a liquor store across the street. He gets out
of the car.

EXT. TRUDY'S CAR/MAIN STREET - CONTINUOUS

John walking away...

FRANK

Well, that's a damn shame, ain't it? You had some arm! Padres were scouting you heavy, weren't they?

TEEN BOY #2

Did you really throw a rock across Salmon Falls River?

Trudy exits Angelo's, pizzas in her arms. Sees John.

TRUDY

John?

John, ignoring everyone, crosses the street. He ducks into the liquor store.

EXT. KIERSTEAD HOME - EVENING

An old clapboard two-storey home. Well-kept. Lights on inside. Trudy's car in the driveway. A sign hangs from the mailbox in the driveway that reads: *The Kiersteads*.

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

John and Trudy at the table. Boxes of Angelo's Pizza between them. Only a few slices remain.

Crowding John are more than a few empty beer bottles. He twists open a fresh one and drinks. Trudy sips on some wine.

They sit in silence like this for a while. The only sounds are the refrigerator running and the ticking of a wall clock somewhere in the b.g., until finally...

TRUDY

You can see him.

JOHN

Huh?

TRUDY

He's at Johnston's Funeral Home.

John, not really acknowledging that remark, looks around the kitchen.

JOHN
What'll happen to this place?

TRUDY
I have an appointment with dad's
estate lawyer. The funeral's been
paid for by the VA and the police
union, but as far as the house, the
cabin...
(pause)
We can talk to the lawyer. Both of
us. Together.

John shrugs. He drinks. Trudy wipes away a sudden tear.

TRUDY (CONT'D)
Three days ago he was sitting right
where you're sitting. In that
chair. We just had a barbecue.
(pause)
He was fine. Everything was fine.

JOHN
He wasn't fine. For years, Tru.

TRUDY
But he was fine! He started running
again. Him and Doug. They ran every
day. He was taking up yoga.

JOHN
Yoga? Dad?

John snickers at the thought.

TRUDY
I know but--

JOHN
He made fun of people who did yoga.
He hated that shit.

TRUDY
Well, he was all for it. He bought
a mat and a membership and... and--

She starts to cry. John gets up and goes over to his little
sister. He hugs her, as she lets it all out.

We hear a church choir begin to sing the classic funeral hymn
"Be Not Afraid", as...

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - JOHN'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

John steps into a bedroom. His old room. Now a guest room. He looks around. It stopped being his room long ago.

LATER

John in bed, unable to sleep. The hymn continues. He finally gets out of bed.

INT. MOTEL LOBBY - LATER

John at a motel front desk, checking in.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - LATER

John in the darkened motel room watching an L.A. Dodgers game on TV and drinking more beer.

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - MORNING

Trudy, housecoat on, cup of coffee in hand, walks down the hallway. She pauses at John's bedroom door. She lays an ear to it. Listens. She knocks.

TRUDY
John? You awake?
(knocks again)
... John?

INT. JOHN'S ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Trudy opens the door. Sees the bed made and no John.

EXT. CEMETERY - DAY

Blustery November day. A sprawling cemetery under a sharp blue sky. CLOSE UP of a HEADSTONE. Etched into the stone:

MACKENZIE "MACKIE" KIERSTEAD - 1953-2023

THERESA KIERSTEAD - 1954-1999

PARENTS OF JOHN & TRUDY

Pull back to a freshly-dug grave, and John, alone, in suit and tie, sitting in the grass next to his parents headstone.

He stares down into the cold pit that is his father's grave.

EXT. CHURCH - CONTINUOUS

Old red-brick Catholic church. A throng of mourners dressed in black file through the wide-open doors.

The church parking lot is packed with cars, spilling out into curbside parking on both sides of the road. We see the hearse parked nearby, along with a convoy of Dover police cruisers.

INT. CHURCH - CONTINUOUS

Full house. Family, friends, members of the community, as well as many from law enforcement and the military. As if all of New Hampshire showed up.

At the lectern, the priest delivers a tearful eulogy--

PRIEST

We are here today to pay our
tribute and our respect to a great
man of God, our brother, our
hero...

The casket up front, flanked by two easels holding framed portraits of Mackie in both his U.S. Marine dress blues and the full dress uniform of the Dover Police Department.

PRIEST (CONT'D)

It has been said, "*The measure of a
life is not in its duration but in
its donation.*" Mackie Kierstead
lived by this axiom, and to its
fullest.

Draped over the casket are the Mackie's uniforms, decorated with bars and medals of exceptional service and bravery. This man was nothing less than a hero.

PRIEST (CONT'D)

We are also here to seek and
receive comfort from God, trusting
that He will minister to our
hearts, and provide us with the
strength to walk with Him during
these unclear times.

Trudy is among the mourners in the front row, red-eyed, and holding tight the hand of her boyfriend, DOUG, 30, also dressed in the full dress uniform of the Dover PD.

PRIEST (CONT'D)
... As Jesus said, "*Blessed are
they that mourn, for they shall be
comforted*".

Trudy turns and scans the congregation, searching for John.
He's nowhere to be found.

But someone does catch her eye -- a man, 60's, in a U.S.
Marines uniform. He's REGGIE. He's in good shape for his age,
but tightly wound.

Reggie senses Trudy. He meets her somber gaze. He gives her a
curt nod, and then looks away.

EXT. CEMETERY - LATER

John sits against the backside of his parent's headstone.
Eyes closed. Almost asleep. He stirs at the sound of the
funeral procession rolling in.

PRIEST (V.O.)
... And from the Philippians: *For
to me to live is Christ, and to die
is gain...*

John stands, sees the Dover Police escort rounding a hilly
bend, and then the hearse...

PRIEST (V.O.)
... *For I am in a strait betwixt
two, having a desire to depart, and
to be with Christ; which is far
better...*

... And then a black Lincoln Town Car, its passenger window
rolled down and framing Trudy's face veiled in black lace.

EXT. CEMETERY - LATER

The interment. The grieving crowd at the grave site as the
priest says a prayer and sprinkles holy water onto the casket
as it's slowly lowered down into the grave.

John is next to Trudy, who stands next to Doug. Trudy dabs
away a tear from her eye. She takes a hold of John's hand,
tightly, and doesn't let go.

EXT. KIERSTEAD HOME - AFTERNOON

Many cars shoe-horned into the Kierstead's driveway. Many more line both sides of the narrow residential street.

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

The mourners have all gathered, everyone a tad less grief-stricken as they drink and eat and swap memorable stories about the late, great Mackie Kierstead.

Doug is busily handing out fresh cans of beers. Trudy tours around with a tray of sandwiches and a pot of coffee.

The DOORBELL rings.

INT. FRONT HALL - MOMENTS LATER

John gets the door. It's Reggie. Still in his Marines uniform. A paper bag bulges under one arm. He steps inside.

REGGIE

Sorry I'm late, kid. Been all over town tryin' to find a bottle.

From the bag Reggie pulls out a bottle of Irish whiskey -- Tullamore Dew. Holds it out to John.

REGGIE (CONT'D)

Mackie's favorite. Your's too, from what I remember?

John smiles. Reggie smiles back. John takes the bottle.

JOHN

Good to see you, Reggie.

The two men hug warmly.

REGGIE

Got smokes?

JOHN

Sure.

INT. LAUNDRY ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

Reggie sits on top of the washing machine. John's at the window looking absently down at the street. Both men are drinking the Tullamore and smoking cigarettes.

REGGIE

A fine thing you've done. Coming back. I know things weren't smooth as butter for you two.

John ignores that remark, still looking out the window at...

JOHN'S POV: a car parked at the end of the street. Early model HONDA hatchback. Idling. A dark figure of a WOMAN sits behind the wheel.

REGGIE (O.S.) (CONT'D)

Let me be the one to say that your father would've appreciated this. I know Trudy does.

John turns from the window.

JOHN

How are you holding up, Reg?

REGGIE

I miss the sonofabitch. But, shit, he had a good run. Mackie was quality. One of the good ones. A true titan.

(pause)

I'd do anything for your father. And he for me. I extend that to you now, John. You and Trudy. Anything you need, just say the word.

JOHN

Yeah. Thanks.

REGGIE

I mean it, kid. Anything.

(pause)

You, uh, speak to the estate lawyer?

John shakes his head 'no'.

JOHN

Tomorrow.

He returns to the window, the Honda. Reggie watches him.

REGGIE

You know, uh, your dad and I spent a lotta time at the cabin. He used to talk about it sometimes, the property, you know?

(MORE)

REGGIE (CONT'D)

If anything should ever happen. He didn't want it going to pot.

JOHN

The cabin will be fine.

REGGIE

Lotta upkeep involved, I don't hafta tell you. Winterizing, drain valves and the plumbing and all that. And then there's external. Needs a new roof. Painting--

JOHN

Doug will be around.

REGGIE

No offense, but Douglas ain't exactly what you'd call a handyman. I mean, the cabin's probably gonna go to you anyway, right?

Suddenly, the laundry room door opens and it's Trudy. Unimpressed.

TRUDY

(to John)

Here you are.

REGGIE

Trudy.

TRUDY

Hi, Reggie. John, we need more ice.

JOHN

Yeah.

TRUDY

And there's a lot of people downstairs who're waiting to see you. At least go say hello.

John crushes out his smoke on the window sill, takes another glimpse at that Honda in the street.

TRUDY (CONT'D)

John?

JOHN

Yes. Fine. I'll get the ice.

John exits. Just Trudy and Reggie now. Reggie gestures to the window where John had been so preoccupied.

REGGIE

Hundred bucks says she never gets
out of her car.

TRUDY

Downstairs, Reggie. Now, please.

Reggie studies her a moment. He knocks back his drink,
shrugs, hops off the washer, and walks out.

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - LIVING ROOM - LATER

John on the couch being spoken to by a couple of cop buddies
of his dad's whom he doesn't even know, or can't remember
knowing.

LATER

John, baseball in hand, giving an elderly man and a little
boy a quick tutorial on how to throw a curveball.

LATER

Trudy takes away empty plates from some guests. She looks
across the room at John who's seated alone off in a corner,
baseball in his hand, cycling rapidly through pitch grips.

Trudy senses his mood. She moves to go to him, but then
hesitates and decidedly walks away.

EXT. KIERSTEAD HOME - FRONT PORCH - DUSK

John alone on the front porch. It's dusk, and the street
lamps up and down the road all turn on at once.

In the new light John spots the Honda again, now parked
almost directly across from John. Silhouetted inside the car
is the figure of the woman.

John straightens, squints at the woman. He begins a casual
move for the stairs.

Suddenly, the car turns on, lurches forward with a quick
squeal, and peels away. John watches as the car rounds the
corner and disappears.

The porch door opens. Doug steps out.

DOUG

Hey, John.

JOHN
Oh, hey, Doug.

DOUG
You, uh, want to be left alone or--

JOHN
No, no. Have a seat. Wanna smoke?

DOUG
Sure. Yeah.

Doug sits. John hands him a cigarette, lights it for him.

DOUG (CONT'D)
It's good to see you home.

JOHN
Yeah. How you doing?

DOUG
Oh, well. Work is work. Keeping the peace. Boy, this opioid thing, though. Epidemic around here.

JOHN
Yeah.

DOUG
I imagine they're keeping you pretty busy out there in L.A., huh?

JOHN
Yeah, I suppose they do.

DOUG
Say... how many homicides you boys got out there this year? So far?

JOHN
Dunno. You sort of lose track of those things after a while, Doug.

DOUG
Right... Wow. L.A. Hey, what do think, uh, the chances are that I guy like me, a cop like me, could get onto the force out there?

John to Doug with a "Don't quit your day job" look.

DOUG (CONT'D)
Yeah. Got our own problems here in Dover, I guess, right?

A moment. Both men smoke. They stare out at the empty street.

DOUG (CONT'D)
Speaking of, um, problems, if it's
all the same with you, I mean, if
you're up for it, I was thinking
you could come down to the station
in the morning and get started.

JOHN
Get started on what?

DOUG
Well, I just assumed you'd wanna
look over your dad's progress. I
arranged all his case notes for
you.

JOHN
What case notes?

DOUG
Missing persons cases aren't
exactly a routine thing around
here, and, well, Mackie was doing
us a pretty huge solid helping out.

John holds a blank look.

DOUG (CONT'D)
Consulting on the Holly Roberts
case?
(pause)
Cheyenne's girl?

JOHN
(stunned)
Cheyenne? Cheyenne's daughter is
missing?

DOUG
Um, for days now...
(then it clicks)
Aw, shit. Jesus, John. I thought
you knew. I'm sorry. I thought
Trudy -- she was gonna--

John goes into the house.

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

Trudy cling wraps a bowl of food, sticks it in the fridge. She starts to load the dishwasher as John walks in and grabs a beer from the fridge. Both seem a bit edgy.

TRUDY

Where are you staying tonight?

JOHN

I'm going back to the motel. Then
I'm flying to L.A. in the morning.

Trudy sighs, shakes her head. She starts stabbing cutlery into the cutlery holder.

TRUDY

I noticed you skipped out on your
own father's funeral.

John drinks his beer, simmering. Trudy cools--

TRUDY (CONT'D)

Look, I know you and dad didn't see
eye-to-eye on things toward the
end, but, what would mom think?

JOHN

Mom's fine with it.

TRUDY

Oh, really?

JOHN

Yes. I asked her this morning at
the cemetery. Said she was fine
with it.

TRUDY

Don't fucking start, man.

Trudy shoves the load of cutlery into the dishwasher and
slams the door shut.

JOHN

You know what else she said? "Hey,
John, look after your little
sister, okay? Because even though
she's all grown up, she can still
act like a complete immature
fucking cunt.

Trudy spins on him.

TRUDY

Hey!

JOHN

No! You hey! When were you gonna
tell me about Cheyenne's girl?

Doug appears. Pauses. Trudy looks to Doug, then back to John.
Her anger dampens. She has no answer.

John glowers. He turns and leaves. A moment. He comes back.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Where's Cheyenne?

TRUDY

She's, uh...

DOUG

Northside. In the townhouses.

John storms out.

TRUDY

Wait, John--

Trudy goes after John. Doug stops her.

DOUG

Nope.

The sound of the front door as it's slammed shut.

INT./EXT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR (DRIVING) - NIGHT

John drives through empty, late-night Dover, passing by
1800's textile mills, credit unions and a Dunkin' Donuts.

INT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR (DRIVING) - NIGHT

Along a stretch of road that skirts the Cocheco River. He
stops at a red light. Across the street is a marina and a
boat landing. John considers it.

22 YEARS AGO...

EXT. GREAT BAY - MOTORBOAT - DAY

Summer. Wide open bay. Blue sky day. YOUNG JOHN (19), ANDY
(19), and two teen girls, one of them YOUNG CHEYENNE (African-
American, pretty) are on a sleek new motorboat.

There's loud music and plenty of beers. Andy is at the helm, beer in hand, smoking a joint.

Young Cheyenne sits close to a shirtless Young John. He's fit, tanned, healthy, and donning a University of Southern California baseball cap.

YOUNG JOHN

So, how'd you convince your dad to let you take the boat out, anyway?

ANDY

Easy. Said a future Hall of Famer wants to go for a rip. How could he say no?

Andy looks back at John and winks. John smiles, takes the praise well, enjoys it, even. Cheyenne looks to John and smiles at him proudly.

ANDY (CONT'D)

When the Padres offer you that fat-ass signing bonus, promise me you'll take me out on your giant new yacht, okay?

YOUNG JOHN

Enough.

The other girl (17), gets out of her seat, beer in hand, and a bit tipsy.

OTHER GIRL

Andy, can I drive the boat now? I wanna drive the boat.

ANDY

First of all, it's called 'piloting'. You pilot a boat.

OTHER GIRL

So let me fly the boat, then.

ANDY

No. Captain Johnny, take over. I need to roll us another fatty.

John chugs his beer, gets up and goes and takes the helm. Andy sits and takes out a bag of weed and rolling papers.

Suddenly, out of nowhere, a pair of JET-SKIERS whizz past the boat. A little too close. Their wake rocks the boat.

ANDY (CONT'D)
Hey, Johnny, watch those fuckin'
jet-ski douchebags.

YOUNG JOHN
I see 'em.

John steadies the boat. Andy shouts at the jet-skiers--

ANDY
Fuck you, assholes! Why don't ya
get a real fuckin' boat?!

OTHER GIRL
Yeah! And some women!

Other Girl throws her middle finger in the air at the jet-skiers. The jet-skiers whip a quick return 180.

YOUNG CHEYENNE
They're coming back.

ANDY
Open her up, Johnny. Show 'em what
she's got.

John thrusts the throttle forward. The motor growls like a beast and the boat lurches and takes off, causing Andy to drop the weed as Other Girl stumbles and falls. She laughs.

Young Cheyenne holds on tight, glances back at the fast-approaching jet-skiers. She turns to John.

YOUNG CHEYENNE
John? I think you should slow down.

The jet-skiers split up, flanking both sides of the boat, hemming it in.

Andy grabs a beer can out of the cooler. Unopened. He whips it as hard as he can at one of the jet-skiers.

The beer can rings off the jet-skier's arm, causing him to recoil, sending the jet-ski into a hard, awkward skid.

John watches the injured jet-skier, unaware of the 2nd skier banking in quick toward the boat.

SCREAMS from the girls. Somebody yells "LOOKOUT!". Everything goes black to the noise of a horrific collision.

THE PRESENT --

INT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR - NIGHT

HONK of a horn. John snaps to, green light. He glances to his rearview at the car waiting behind him. John drives on.

INT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR (DRIVING) - NIGHT

Through the windshield POV of John pulling into an apartment complex made up of older 3-story townhouse buildings.

He spots something of interest at the rear-most building. It's the little Honda. He pulls up to it, stops.

He glances down at the parking stall number painted on the asphalt: 305.

EXT. UNIT 305 - MOMENTS LATER

John knocks on the door to 305. The door opens revealing CHEYENNE, now late-30's, and wearing an apron smeared with chocolate icing. She gives John a small, forgiving smile.

CHEYENNE

... Hey.

JOHN

Hey.

They linger a moment in the doorway, holding each other's gaze. Studying one another. Revisiting a storied history as their expressions do the remembering for them.

INT. CHEYENNE'S TOWNHOUSE - LATER

Cheyenne in the kitchen as she puts on a fresh pot of coffee. John's in the living room. He hasn't taken off his coat.

The townhouse has been cheaply, yet thoughtfully, decorated. Ikea meets Thrift Store -- the fake-it-till-you-make-it effort of a struggling single mother.

John looks in at the kitchen, spots on the counter a freshly-baked chocolate cake and a bowl of chocolate icing.

CHEYENNE (O.S.)

Look, I'm sorry about this
afternoon...

John turns to studying the living room.

JOHN
It's alright.

Off in the corner sits a Lazy Boy recliner and a small table holding a few framed PHOTOS of Holly. Empty box of tissues sits next to it. And a nondescript bottle of PILLS.

CHEYENNE (O.S.)
I thought I'd be able to see you,
but...

Cheyenne enters the living room, coffees in hand.

JOHN
I said it's alright.

CHEYENNE
I'm sorry about Mackie. You know he
meant a lot to me. He meant a lot
to a lot of people.
(pause)
How are you doing?

John picks up a Holly photo. A school photo. Recent. 5th Grade. He holds onto it, looks to Cheyenne.

JOHN
What happened to her?

Cheyenne sets down the coffees. She sits.

CHEYENNE
All she wanted for her birthday was
a new hobbyhorse -- you know, those
stuffed toy horses on sticks? All
her friends have 'em. It's like the
new thing. But she was always stuck
using second hand horses her
friends didn't want. She wanted one
she could call her own.

Cheyenne takes out her phone, shows John a photo of a hobbyhorse.

CHEYENNE (CONT'D)
Custom made. Exactly what she
wanted.
(smiles)
Supposed to be a surprise, but
she's such a sneak, she found it,
robbed it right out of the trunk of
my car. Her and her friends went
down to the nature preserve with
it... the day she went missing.
(MORE)

CHEYENNE (CONT'D)

(pause)

That's the only thing of Holly's
the police ever found.

Cheyenne looks to him. She turns on a hopeful expression.

CHEYENNE (CONT'D)

Trudy... she, um, she said you
might be able to help? Mackie, he
was--

JOHN

When was her birthday?

A moment. Cheyenne looks away.

CHEYENNE

Tomorrow.

John's eyes go back to that cake in the kitchen.

CHEYENNE (CONT'D)

I understand if you don't want to
help.

POV John: on the photo of Holly in his hand. He slides the
photo out of its frame sleeve.

JOHN

Can I have this?

Pause. Cheyenne nods.

CHEYENNE

Yes.

EXT. DOVER - NIGHT

John's rental car as it drives through Dover.

INT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR - DAWN

Parked in an empty parking lot at a local park. John behind
the wheel. We hold on him, as the sound of a boat engine
builds slowly...

22 YEARS AGO...

EXT. POLICE BOAT - DAY

A police boat as it motors toward the Dover coast and the marina. The once sunny summer day has now clouded over.

On board are Young John, Cheyenne, and Other Girl. All wrapped in thermal blankets and looking pale and in shock.

Andy is nowhere to be seen.

Up ahead, a Dover Police DIVE BOAT fast approaches. It speeds past us and toward the open waters. John looks over at the dive boat and the police officers in their diving suits.

EXT. MARINA - DAY

A worried MACKIE KIERSTEAD (50) stands at the edge of the dock. He looks out at the police boat approaching the shore.

Behind Mackie sits his unmarked police cruiser and a waiting ambulance and EMS personnel.

THE PRESENT --

INT. DOVER POLICE PRECINCT - EVIDENCE ROOM - DAY

Overlooking a table in an evidence room. Holly's custom-made hobbyhorse sits bagged and tagged in the middle of the table.

INT. MOTEL ROOM - MORNING

The night stand. John sets a fresh bottle of whiskey down next to his BOARDING PASS to L.A. and a folded-up funeral program, Mackie's portrait on the front looking up at us.

He places the Holly photo onto the night stand, gently. He plops down onto the bed. He lays back. He stares across at the Holly photo.

INT. DOVER POLICE PRECINCT - EVIDENCE ROOM - DAY

John at the evidence table looking down at Holly's hobbyhorse.

The door opens behind him and Doug enters with a thick accordion folder under his arm. Doug sets the folder down next to the hobbyhorse.

DOUG
Mackie's work.

A moment. John glances over at the folder.

DOUG (O.S.) (CONT'D)
You can sign it out before you
leave.
(pause)
Just let us know if you need
anything else.

John nods. He returns to the hobbyhorse. Doug exits.

John digs out his phone. He takes some photos of the bagged hobbyhorse.

He snaps on a pair of latex gloves, and opens the bag. He lifts out the hobbyhorse. Examines it. Takes more photos.

INT. LAWYER'S OFFICE - DAY

Trudy sits with an estate lawyer as she signs off on a flurry of legal documents. The lawyer slides the keys and deed to the cabin into a large envelope labelled "John".

INT. DOVER POLICE PRECINCT - DAY

A clerk's desk. John signs off on his father's case files.

INT. PRECINCT - HALLWAY - MOMENTS LATER

John walks the precinct hallway, passing the Dover PD Wall of Fame -- portraits of past police chiefs and exceptional service men and women.

At the end of the hall, a maintenance worker affixes a framed portrait of Mackie to the wall. John passes by the tribute, barely acknowledging it.

22 YEARS AGO...

INT./EXT. MACKIE'S UNMARKED/MARINA - DAY

A hard rain falls on Dover, as Young John stares out the window at Cheyenne being led into the back of an ambulance.

Mackie approaches us. He opens the door and gets in and shuts the door. He looks to his son, then out at the marina, at Cheyenne and the ambulance. His expression unreadable.

MACKIE
They're gonna ask you some
questions.

Young John nods. Mackie looks to his son.

MACKIE (CONT'D)
Those jet-skiers say it was
provoked.

YOUNG JOHN
They came at us, dad. We were
just... I ran out of room.

MACKIE
They failed the Breathalyzer.
Whatever they say happened won't
matter anyway.

(pause)
But Andy shouldn't have been
drinking.

YOUNG JOHN
We were all drinking. And, Dad, I
was the one who was--

MACKIE
Wouldn't have happened had he been
sober. He took his father's boat
without asking and--

YOUNG JOHN	MACKIE (CONT'D)
His dad let him use the boat.	Operating a watercraft while under the influence.

... Dad--

MACKIE
He put everyone's safety in danger.

YOUNG JOHN
Dad, I told you I was the one--

MACKIE
John. Listen to me--

YOUNG JOHN
Andy didn't do anything, Dad.

KNOCKS on Mackie's window. It's a DOVER COP in a rain poncho.

YOUNG JOHN (CONT'D)
He didn't do anything.

Mackie rolls down his the window.

MACKIE

What?

Cop looks at John, then at Mackie.

DOVER COP

Dive team made a recovery...

Positive I.D.

Mackie nods, rolls up the window as the Cop walks away.

YOUNG JOHN

We don't have to do this.

MACKIE

John, you're not listening.

YOUNG JOHN

Dad, it's okay. I'll say it was me.

The jet skiers. I panicked--

MACKIE

John! You fucked up. You can't undo this. You want to ruin two lives now?

YOUNG JOHN

You're not putting this on Andy.

MACKIE

Andy's dead.

(pause)

Got that? Now, listen to me--

YOUNG JOHN

But I was the one. Don't put it on him.

MACKIE

Listen to me, John! Are you out of your fucking mind?! You guys crossed state lines. Did you know that?

John's look: clearly he was not aware.

MACKIE (CONT'D)

Maine State Police are gonna jump all over this. They're gonna wanna know what happened on their watch.

(pause)

(MORE)

MACKIE (CONT'D)
You tell 'em whatever the hell you
want. But remember, as soon as you
talk, I can't protect you.

Mackie starts the car. Puts it in gear.

MACKIE (CONT'D)
Besides, you got baseball coming
up.

Mackie, all business, drives on. John sits stunned.

THE PRESENT --

EXT. APARTMENT BALCONY - RESEDA, CALIFORNIA - DAY

A not-too-shabby apartment complex in sunny Reseda. Angie the
hooker sits on her balcony in a skimpy 2-piece, drinking beer
and painting her toenails a bright blue. Her phone rings.

ANGIE
(answering)
Where you at, baby John?

INT. MOTEL ROOM - DAY

John zips his suitcase shut. He's checking-out.

JOHN
I'm not home right now.

John pockets his boarding pass from off the night stand.

ANGIE (ON PHONE)
Well, where you at? I'll swing by.

INT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR (DRIVING) - DAY

John drives through Dover.

JOHN (O.S.)
Ang... how does a person know if
they're doing the right thing?

ANGIE (O.S.)
Just come back home where you
belong, baby. A'ight? I'll fuck
your brains out. On the house.

Road sign: Airport exit. John drives past it.

JOHN (O.S.)
I gotta know, Ang.

EXT. KIERSTEAD HOME - DAY

John's rental parked in the Kierstead driveway.

ANGIE (O.S.)
Man, I don't know. Ya just... I
guess ya just feel something?

JOHN (O.S.)
What do you feel?

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

John enters the kitchen. Sees his envelope from the estate lawyer sitting on the table. He sets down his luggage.

ANGIE (O.S.)
I haven't always done the right
thing. Duh. But, ya know, whether
right or wrong, John, we all got a
voice in our head...

John goes to the envelope. He opens it.

ANGIE (O.S.) (CONT'D)
It'll never tell ya what to do. But
it'll always tell ya what NOT to
do.

EXT. KIERSTEAD HOME - BACKYARD - DAY

Trudy in the backyard vegetable garden, toiling away,
harvesting the last of this autumn's crop -- pumpkin, squash,
corn.

ANGIE (O.S.)
I guess ya gotta listen for that,
ya know?

Trudy hears the back door swing open. She turns and sees John
standing there, twirling the cabin keys on his finger. She
puts down her garden tools and goes to John. She hugs him.

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - KITCHEN - MORNING

Eggs and bacon sizzle on a frying pan on the Kierstead stove.

JOHN (O.S.)
Who exactly has been questioned?

John and Doug are seated at the table. Doug's in his police uniform, wolfing down his breakfast. John has barely touched his plate, his side of the table covered with case reports and police photos.

DOUG
(eats, thinks)
Uh, the warden at the nature preserve. Holly's father Pete. Cheyenne, of course. It's all in Mackie's reports.

JOHN
(flipping through files)
Incomplete reports.

Trudy at the stove, glances to John.

TRUDY
I was thinking: why don't we all go to the cabin this weekend? Catch the fall colors before they're gone?

DOUG
Sure, honey.

JOHN
Reggie says the place needs work.
(to Doug)
What about the girls?

DOUG
Girls?

JOHN
Cheyenne mentioned Holly was with some friends the day she went missing.

DOUG
Right. Mackie talked to them. There should be a transcript of it in there.

Doug reaches across with greasy fingers, grabs a handful of papers and sifts through them for the transcripts.

TRUDY

You know Reggie's been trying to
get dad to sell him the cabin.
Don't be surprised if he asks you.

Doug finds it.

DOUG

Here. Right there.

He hands John a single page. John takes it, scans it.

JOHN

Where's the rest? This is a blurb,
barely half a page.

DOUG

This is it. I mean... the girls,
they were pretty shook up when I
questioned them the night Holly
disappeared. Apparently still shook
up when Mackie talked to them.

John's POV: 8 X 10 photo of Holly's hobbyhorse.

JOHN (O.S.)

Those girls are the last people to
have seen Holly alive. They need to
be questioned again.

DOUG

Right. I'll get on it.

JOHN

No. I'll do it.

Trudy comes over with the skillet of eggs, bacon. She serves
a heap of it onto John's plate. It goes unnoticed by John
who's now hyper-focused on the hobbyhorse photo.

He draws closer to the photo, squints at it. Trudy goes to
refill John's glass of OJ. He puts his hand over his glass.

TRUDY

What is it?

John with the photo springs out of his seat and leaves the
kitchen.

INT. MACKIE'S DEN - KIERSTEAD HOME - MOMENTS LATER

A table laid out with fly-tying hobby equipment. A magnifying lamp sits clamped to the table. John and Doug both peer through the magnifying lens.

ANGLE ON: the magnifying lamp. The hobbyhorse photo is slipped behind the lens. The image zooms up at us.

DOUG (O.S.)
Oh, yeah. Wood's been stamped.

Words branded into the wooden stick of the hobbyhorse read:

Land & Sea Woodworks. Biddeford, Maine.

JOHN (O.S.)
Cheyenne said she had it custom
made...
(reads the inscription)
... Land and sea woodworks?

John looks to Doug who shrugs and shakes his head "no".

DOUG
Never heard of it. I think it's an
angle your dad never thought of,
though.

John's look says he isn't entirely convinced.

INT./EXT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR/ARENA - DAY

John's car. Mackie's case files rest on the dash. Through the windshield we see people filing in and out of a local hockey arena -- young girls, parents and spectators.

Beth and Krista are seen entering the arena, hobbyhorses poking out of gym bags slung over their shoulders.

INT. ARENA - DAY

A show jumping course has been set up on the arena floor. Girls with hobbyhorses run the course and perform dressage. Judges mark and score their rounds.

ARENA SEATS

John and Beth and Krista sit in the stands. Both girls seem not in the best of spirits.

BETH

I don't get why we gotta talk about this stuff over and over. Don't you cops share notes?

JOHN

I'm sorry that you have to answer all these questions. I know that the past week has been very rough. For the both of you.

KRISTA

We just want Holly back.

JOHN

I know. I do, too. Now, is there anything else you can remember -- about that day? The day before? The week before? Anything?

BETH

We said no. What else are we supposed to say? We don't know what she did 24 hours a day. We don't know what her thoughts were. How am I supposed to know where she rides her bike when I'm not around, or what emails she gets, or who some random she was texting all the time was?

JOHN

Was she texting someone? A stranger?

Beth, big sigh. She gives up. Krista chimes in--

KRISTA

A friend.

JOHN

Which friend?

BETH

Duh! She never said who.

JOHN

Krista?

KRISTA

She wouldn't tell us.

JOHN
Was it a boy? Someone she went to
school with maybe?

BETH
No. Body. Knows.

KRISTA
She called him El Vaquero.

JOHN
El Vaquero? The Cowboy?

An announcer over the PA calls the next competitors.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Why didn't you tell this to
Detective Kierstead when he
interviewed you?

Announcer calls Beth and Krista. Beth gets out of her seat.
She flashes John a snarky look--

BETH
We did tell him.

She heads down to the competition floor. Krista lingers a
moment, awkwardly, then gets up and follows Beth. She stops
and turns to John.

KRISTA
Holly was always nice to me. I
really hope you find her.

She turns back and heads off down to the arena floor.

EXT. FOOD TRUCK - DAY

A waterfront fish and chips truck. Doug and John walk away
from it carrying darkly-greased take-out bags. John opens his
bag, peeks into it. He winces.

JOHN
Thirty bucks? And for what?

He pulls out of the bag a skimpy piece of battered cod. It's
mostly batter.

JOHN (CONT'D)
You know, I expect this in L.A.,
but here...
(peeks into bag again)
It's all fucking french fries.

Doug shrugs. He tosses a fistful of fries into his mouth.

DOUG

I read in the paper... seventy
percent of our seafood is
exported...

(pause)

To New York. If ya can believe it.

They arrive at Doug's police cruiser. John sets down his food, bothered by something else besides the fish.

JOHN

I don't understand. Why would he
leave something like that out?

DOUG

What? Oh. El Vaquero?

JOHN

And the dates. Timelines. Says he
spoke to the girls Monday, but it
was really Sunday.

DOUG

John. Don't take this the wrong way
or anything, but you haven't been
around. Mackie was in rough shape.
I mean, who knows? Maybe his memory
was fading.

JOHN

No. He's a better cop than that.

(pause)

It's like he knew that somebody
would be reading his notes...
somebody he didn't want reading
them.

DOUG

Don't look into it like that. We
got a lead. That's enough for me.

JOHN

It's a bullshit report, man. And
you know it.

Doug takes the insult on behalf of himself and Mackie. He checks his watch.

DOUG

You're gonna miss your ferry.

John looks down at his seafood. Picks through the fries for any morsels of actual fish. He gives up.

JOHN
Get her cell number.

DOUG
Holly? We did that. It's dead.

JOHN
Do it again. Call her provider,
bring up her records, see who she
was texting.

John turns and walks away.

DOUG
How far back?

JOHN
As far as you can get.

EXT. FERRY - DAY

On the ferry. John emerges from his car. He lights a cigarette and heads over to the ferry's edge.

It's overcast with a cold, bitter wind. John pops his collar to shield the bite. He draws his coat in for warmth. A world away from sunny Los Angeles.

He casts his gaze out across the bay, to the island still far off but drawing nearer with every passing moment.

The island: Desolate. Rugged. Almost ominous, shaded darkly by dense pines and firs that push to the extreme edges of the shoreline -- as if the trees themselves are desperate to escape something.

EXT. ISLAND - OLD ROAD - DAY

Old island road. Barely maintained. John's rental appears from around the bend, passing by us.

INT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR - DAY

POV: through the windshield as John idles at a private side road blocked by a low-hung chain strung across its entrance.

We stay here as John gets out and goes to the chain, unlocks one end with his cabin keys, and lets the chain fall.

He comes back to the car and gets in, and then we drive off down the private dirt road a ways until John suddenly has to hit the brakes for--

A pick-up truck blocking the road. It's Reggie's truck.

EXT. REGGIE'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

A U.S. Marines decal in the back window. A rifle rack hangs above it, clutching a 12 gauge shotgun with a scope.

John walks up. Checks out Reggie's truck. He then walks on down the dirt road.

EXT. CLEARING - DAY

John exits the road and into a grassy clearing and the cabin on the other side. It's a white clapboard A-frame, old and small but well-maintained.

The whine of a power saw is heard from somewhere on the other side of the cabin.

EXT. CABIN - BACKYARD - CONTINUOUS

A half-built patio sits over an old root cellar.

WITH REGGIE

He's bent over a plank of wood, cutting through it with the power saw. He senses something. He stops his cut. The saw powers down. He straightens, turns. Smiles.

REGGIE

John.

We see John standing here, cabin keys dangling from his finger.

JOHN

Reggie.

INT. CABIN - DAY

The kitchen. Cozy. Rustic. Reggie rummages in the fridge.

REGGIE

Had I'd known you were coming...

He comes up with two beers.

REGGIE (CONT'D)
... I'd have brought along a few
more beers.

He hands a bottle to John, who takes it.

JOHN
And had I'd known you were
coming...

Reggie pauses. An almost sheepish smile as he twists open his
beer and flicks the bottle cap into the sink.

REGGIE
Yeah. Heard the place is all yours
now. Congrats.

They clink bottles. Cheers.

REGGIE (CONT'D)
The patio was one of our projects.
I thought it'd be fitting to see it
through.

JOHN
That's fine.

John wanders off into the living room. Reggie follows.

REGGIE
So, uh, what brings you out here
today, anyway?

INT. LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Lived in. Cluttered with take-out containers and empty beer
cans. Dirty laundry lay strewn across the floor and around
the pull-out couch. Clearly Reggie's been sleeping here.

John soaks it all in.

JOHN
... Twenty years.

REGGIE
What?

JOHN
It's been twenty years since I
stepped foot in here.

REGGIE

When you and Trudy were kids, you used to come out here, those hot fuckin' summers, remember? You'd be out back practicing your pitches.

John turns his gaze to the fireplace mantle that holds a few framed photos. He walks over to it.

REGGIE (CONT'D)

Poor Trudy, you'd force her to swing that old bat over and over. Remember that?

One of the photos is of a younger John (10), beaming, holding up a modest looking trout. Fresh catch.

REGGIE (CONT'D)

(laughs)

After a few swings it was like she was trying to lift a tree trunk, she was so exhausted.

John lifts up the photo, looks at it closely.

REGGIE (O.S.) (CONT'D)

But you were good, John. Real good. You had tremendous talent.

John sets the photo back onto the mantle.

JOHN

Reggie? Where were you the day Holly Roberts disappeared?

Reggie, a bit startled.

REGGIE

Pardon?

John turns to Reggie.

JOHN

I've agreed to look into the case.

Reggie, offended--

REGGIE

Is that why you're here? To question me?

JOHN

Nah. Just procedure. I couldn't find any record of PD or my dad ever speaking to you. Thought I'd just dot that "i".

REGGIE

C'mon, John. Least stay in the damn strike zone, will ya?

JOHN

What do you mean?

REGGIE

Look, if I were you, I'd be taking a hard look at that hombre Cheyenne's been rolling with.

JOHN

And which hombre would that be?

REGGIE

Gang-banger. From Boston. Yeah. He drives around in some gaudy Chrysler 300. Doug didn't tell ya?

John seems disturbed by this. He swigs his beer. He heads back into the kitchen.

REGGIE (CONT'D)

It's them fuckin' opiates, you know. They're here.

INT. KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

John puts on his coat. Reggie enters.

REGGIE

And Cheyenne... She's gone got herself all mixed up in it. Deep.

JOHN

Doesn't really concern you, Reggie.

REGGIE

Oh, but it does. This is my town. This was Mackie's town. It's still your town, too, John.

JOHN

I'm just doing a favor. That's it.

John turns to go.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Thanks for the beer.

He's almost out the door, stops, comes back.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Say, Reggie?

REGGIE
What?

JOHN
My father ever speak privately to
you about the Holly Roberts case?

Reggie gives pause, visibly annoyed.

REGGIE
Matter of fact he did.

John thinks for a moment. Nods. He turns and leaves. That's
it. No further questions.

JOHN
Make sure you lock up when you're
done.

Reggie takes a slug of beer and watches John through the
window walk across the clearing back toward the road.

EXT. TOWNHOUSE COMPLEX - DAY

The townhouses. A hard November rain pummels everything. In a
far corner of the parking lot sits John's car.

INT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR - DAY

John in his car. Radio tuned to AM sports talk. Baseball. Red
Sox off-season and the upcoming college draft.

John sips on a cup of coffee, Dunkin' Donuts. He hits the
wipers to refresh his view of Cheyenne's townhouse building.

EXT. TOWNHOUSE - CONTINUOUS

Cheyenne emerges from her townhouse in a waitress uniform.
She looks a bit strung out. She pauses under the entrance way
overhang and lights a cigarette. She hops on her phone.

INT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR - CONTINUOUS

John with an eye on Cheyenne. Over the AM radio--

RADIO HOST

College pitching is a strength in this year's draft. Our righty out of Florida, Emerson Spencer, will likely go #1. Deep toolbox of pitches, an ability to pound the strike zone, and a 98-mph fastball, the kid's a stud-force. Absolute savage.

CLICK. John's shuts the radio off. He flips the hood up on his coat and zips up and goes to exit the car, but then...

A DEEP ROLLING NOISE. Lots of rhythm and bass. John checks his rearview: a pair of headlights from a car slowly approaches through the rain.

The car gets closer, the noise growing louder. John's windows begin to vibrate from the soundwaves.

It's gangsta rap. As the car passes, John can see clearly it's a Chrysler 300, black and with Massachusetts plates. It pulls up to Cheyenne. She hops in and the 300 drives off.

INT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR (DRIVING) - DAY

John in traffic tailing the 300. The rain has switched over to sleet making for slower than usual traffic.

Intersection. Red light. Everyone slows to a stop, as John creeps over into the adjacent lane alongside the 300 passenger side.

Inside, sits Cheyenne. She raps along to the music, cigarette in her hand. John peeks past and over at the driver: he's Hispanic, 30's, hoodie and a Boston Celtics ball cap.

Cheyenne senses eyes on her. She glances over and does a double-take as she meets John's gaze. She stops rapping.

The two of them hold a look. Cheyenne looks away first.

John's phone rings. Without taking his eyes off Cheyenne, he answers--

JOHN

Yeah?

INT. DOVER POLICE PRECINCT - CONTINUOUS

Doug at his desk, looking at his computer screen.

DOUG
T-Mobile records came in.

INTERCUT JOHN/DOUG

JOHN
Good. And?

DOUG
Mostly text messages to friends.
And Cheyenne.

Green light. Traffic moves. John falls back and switches lanes again to stay behind the 300.

DOUG (CONT'D)
But there's this other number. No longer in service. T-Mobile says it was probably one of them Wal-Mart burner-phone dealies? So I tracked the tower pings, and the last call made on that number was the morning Holly went missing.

JOHN
Okay.

DOUG
Guess where the tower is?

JOHN
Where?

DOUG
Biddeford.

JOHN
... Land and Sea Woodworks.

DOUG
I'll call Maine staties.

JOHN
No. Don't. I'll be fine.

DOUG
John, you can't just go and--

JOHN
I need you to run a plate. Ready?

DOUG
Just wait a minute--

JOHN
Mass plate. 2BF J9E. Got it?

The 300 pulls over to a Denny's restaurant. John pulls over.

DOUG
Listen to me, John -- don't go to
Biddeford.

Cheyenne hops out of the 300 and rushes into the Denny's.

JOHN
2BF J9E. Do you copy that?

DOUG
Yes. I got it. But, look...

Doug glances around the office, leans into his phone.

DOUG (CONT'D)
You're already way out of your
jurisdiction. So promise me that
you won't go--

CLICK. John's hangs up.

DOUG (CONT'D)
Shit. Shit-fuck-shit.

INT. LAND & SEA WOODWORKS - DAY

Close up of wood being cut by a power saw. Shots of workers sanding, hammering, operating machinery. More than a few workers are visibly mentally disabled.

INT. LAND & SEA WOODWORKS - FRONT OFFICE - DAY

John in business casual attire talking with the receptionist. From the shop floor enters a MANAGEMENT type, 50's. He greets John.

MANAGEMENT
Mr. Matthews, thank you for coming.

They two men shake hands.

JOHN
Thanks for having me on such short
notice.

MANAGEMENT

My pleasure.

Management motions to the shop floor door.

MANAGEMENT (CONT'D)

Shall we get started?

JOHN

Absolutely.

INT. SHOP FLOOR - DAY

Management giving John a tour of the noisy shop floor--

MANAGEMENT

We run mainly a production line of furniture and cabinetry, with a few custom lines here and there.

More shots of workers busily assembling wood products at various stages of completion.

JOHN

How many workers do you employ?

MANAGEMENT

Depends on the size of the run. 20 to 30 on average. We're also unique in that our workforce is an integrated workforce, consisting of, as you can see, folks with and without disabilities.

We focus on one young Hispanic man, 20's, operating a lathe machine. He clearly is not one of the disabled.

JOHN

What about last year's earnings?

MANAGEMENT

Last year was a particularly good sales year. 3 million in revenue stream, a large chunk of which we funnel back into services and programs for the disabled.

The young Hispanic takes notice of the two men, showing particular concern towards John.

MANAGEMENT (CONT'D)
 You mentioned your company's
 interested in our premium line of
 custom hobbyhorses?

John scans the faces of the workers, lands on the Hispanic.
 He and John trade a look.

MANAGEMENT (CONT'D)
 Mr. Matthews?

The Hispanic returns to his work.

MANAGEMENT (CONT'D)
 Mr. Matthews?

John to Management--

JOHN
 Sorry?

MANAGEMENT
 You're interested in hobbyhorses?

Management leads John to an office just off the shop floor.

INT. OFFICE - MOMENTS LATER

Management hands John some sales brochures, motions John to
 have a seat.

John sits, positioning himself with a view through the office
 window and the young Latino at his lathe machine.

JOHN
 My company. We are very excited to
 branch out into the toy and hobby
 market.

MANAGEMENT
 Well, we run a couple hobbyhorse
 lines. One in late spring, the
 other closer to the Christmas
 season.

JOHN
 Now, do you assign certain skilled
 workers to those lines?

MANAGEMENT
 Yes, we do, actually. The horses
 are all hand-made, custom painted,
 air-brushed.

(MORE)

MANAGEMENT (CONT'D)

We cut our own leather for the
bridles. It's a specialty line that
we here at land and sea take
particular pride in.

JOHN

Is it at all possible if I could
meet the hobbyhorse makers?

MANAGEMENT

Matter of fact, we got one of our
makers on the floor right now. Let
me call him in.

Management picks up his office phone, hits the PA button.

EXT. SHOP FLOOR - CONTINUOUS

With the Hispanic, nervous, sweating.

MANAGEMENT

(over PA, in Spanish)

Ricardo. Come to my office, please.

RICARDO freezes. He looks over at the office and spots John
in the window staring out at him with a dubious look.

Ricardo shuts off his machine. He takes his time removing his
protective eye wear, his gloves, and his ear plugs.

INT. OFFICE - CONTINUOUS

John POV: as Ricardo leaves his station and begins to walk
toward us...

Suddenly, he takes an abrupt turn and heads briskly down a
hallway.

JOHN

Fuck.

MANAGEMENT

What's going on?

John races out the door.

MANAGEMENT (CONT'D)

Hey!

INT. SHOP FLOOR - CONTINUOUS

John bolts across the shop toward the hallway where Ricardo disappeared. A woman carrying an arm-load of wood appears. John doesn't stop, bumps her hard but keeps running.

The wood and the woman spill to the floor. Co-workers quickly come to her aid. We see she clearly has Down's Syndrome. She is deeply shocked and very upset at being hit.

INT. HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

John sprints the hallway just as the exit door at the end swings shut. He reaches the door, shoulders through it, and bursts out into...

EXT. LUMBER YARD - CONTINUOUS

Lumber yard. The shock of freezing rain. John spots Ricardo fleeing toward a chain-link fence at the opposite end of the yard. John sprints after him.

JOHN
Ricardo! Stop!

AT THE FENCE

A sloping pile of rough-hewn lumber stacked against the fence. Ricardo hits it, climbs up, and leaps over the fence, dropping into...

EXT. STORAGE LOT - CONTINUOUS

A storage lot filled with rows of parked tractor trailers. Ricardo cuts between trailers and disappears from sight.

EXT. LUMBER YARD - CONTINUOUS

John gets to the fence, bounds up the wood pile. The wood is slick with frozen rain. He loses his footing and stumbles hard onto the cold heavy lumber.

JOHN
Fuck!

He gets up and keeps going, wincing as he gingerly climbs the fence and drops into the storage lot.

EXT. STORAGE LOT - CONTINUOUS

John moves slowly between two trailers, stopping at the end to peer around the corners. He moves ahead down another corridor of trailers.

He pauses. Listens. Tough to hear anything over the sharp sound of sleet cutting against the metal of the trailers.

He reaches for his gun...

Shit. Muscle memory. He never did bring his gun from L.A.

Then a dull THUD from above. John looks up and glimpses Ricardo on the roof of a nearby trailer.

JOHN
Ricardo! Police! Stop right now!

Ricardo leaps off and onto another trailer roof. The race is on. Ricardo above and John below. John makes a shortcut diagonally between rows, trying to keep up with Ricardo.

John stops between trailers. He's lost sight of Ricardo. Checks out the corners. He peeks underneath. Nothing.

Suddenly, a dark shape soars above between the trailers. Then a thud as Ricardo lands on the roof.

A metal ladder bolted to the trailer end. John climbs it.

EXT. TRAILER ROOF - CONTINUOUS

John appears at the edge and catches Ricardo making another leap over onto one more trailer up ahead.

John climbs onto the roof, swallows his nerves and breaks into a run to the other end... LEAPS the gap onto...

EXT. OTHER TRAILER ROOF - CONTINUOUS

John lands. Ricardo watches from the other end. They exchange a look, then Ricardo turns and leaps off onto the ground.

John sprints to the end, makes a leap of faith off the trailer. Soars. Committed. Then arms flailing until his fall is broken as he pounces hard onto Ricardo.

Both men crash to the muddy half-frozen dirt of the lot. John to his knees. Ricardo lies there. Wind knocked out of him. He groans.

John stands, out of breath, adrenalin pumping. He smiles--

JOHN
Got you, El Vaquero.

He yanks Ricardo to his feet.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Who's the cowboy now? Huh?!

EXT. FOREST - DAY

We move over a bare, leafless forest -- dozens of search team volunteers in bright orange vests fan out across the forest floor.

EXT. DOVER - DAY

A missing persons poster of Holly stapled to a telephone pole. Half the poster is encrusted with sleet, the other half barely hanging on, whipped by the gusty winds.

INT. DOVER POLICE PRECINCT - DAY

John paces outside a door in a secluded alcove sectioned off from the rest of the precinct.

The door opens and Doug comes out of a room that certainly isn't any official interrogation room. He looks around, worried. John goes to him, expectant:

JOHN
What'd he say?

DOUG
Why did you have to bring him here?

JOHN
What? We supposed to grill the guy in some back alley? Tell me what he said.

DOUG
I didn't get much out of him.
Except he thought you were ICE.

JOHN
What?

DOUG
Immigration. That's why he ran.

Doug produces a Social Security card. John takes it, looks it over.

DOUG (CONT'D)
Says he bought it off the street
down in Boston.

JOHN
That's all?

INT. ROOM - MOMENTS LATER

John sits down across from Ricardo, who's cut-up and exhausted from the foot chase. Doug's here, too, standing at the door, keeping a close eye out the door's little window.

****the preceeding exchange will be spoken in Spanish with English subtitles****

JOHN
How long you been working there?

RICARDO
Six months.

JOHN
You like it here? You like America?
You can support your kids with that
pay check?
(without giving Ricardo a
chance--)
Oh, that's right, you don't have
any kids. You're here all alone.
You're a loner. Guess what?

John slaps the fake Social Security card onto the table.

JOHN (CONT'D)
That card is fraudulent. That makes
you a fraud. Now, I'm calling ICE
unless you tell me what you know.

Ricardo, confused, scared--

RICARDO
I know nothing. I swear. I just
work. I love America.

JOHN
Bullshit. You make hobbyhorses?

RICARDO
Yes.

JOHN
Who else? Who's on your team?

RICARDO
My team?

JOHN
Who makes the fucking hobbyhorses,
Ricardo?! Who else?!

Doug shifts uncomfortably, concerned at John's temper. He takes a quick peek out the door window.

John stares down Ricardo, waiting. Finally...

RICARDO
Two other men. Alberto Gomez and
Raymond Olsen.

JOHN
Alberto and Raymond. Okay. Good.
More. Tell me more.

RICARDO
Raymond no longer works with us.
They fired him a month ago.

JOHN
Why'd they fire him?

Ricardo shrugs.

RICARDO
I still see him at the bar.

JOHN
What bar?

RICARDO
(in English)
Silver Dollar Saloon.

Doug hears the name, perks up. John looks over at him.

DOUG
Remember O'Leary's Pub? Across from
the Legion?

John nods. He turns back to Ricardo.

JOHN
Tell me about Alberto.

RICARDO

Alberto lives in Dover. We all used to go the bar every Friday night after work. He's a very good friend of mine.

JOHN

I wanna talk to Alberto.

RICARDO

He hasn't been to work in a week. I check his apartment. He not there either. I think ICE get him. That's why I run from you.

John leans back in his chair, puzzled, trying to fit the pieces together. Suddenly--

DOUG (O.S.)

Oh, shit.

John turns, sees Doug backing away from the door as it swings open and CAPTAIN MARCHAND enters.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

Douglas.

(re: Ricardo)

Take his statement and cut him loose.

(to John, stern)

You. Come with me.

John sighs, stands, and goes with the Captain.

INT. CAPTAIN MARCHAND'S OFFICE - DAY

The Captain sits at his desk. He shakes his head at John who sits in front of him.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

I can't believe I'm saying this --
You are not a member of this police force.

JOHN

Yes, sir. I understand that, sir.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

You are not a member of Homeland Security. Or Immigration. You're certainly not FBI.

John nods, takes his punches.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND (CONT'D)

You are an outside agent acting in a consultancy role with the Dover Police Department on an active missing persons investigation. You review the available information that we provide, and in turn give your educated opinion to us based on the facts at hand.

(pause)

Clear?

JOHN

Yes, sir. Crystal.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

Then do you care to tell me why you've been running all over New England playing a bad Dick Tracy?

JOHN

Sir?

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

Arresting innocent individuals, dragging them across state lines, and accusing them of--

JOHN

I didn't arrest him. I detained him. And he's an illegal.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

That's not your job!

JOHN

He ran from me.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

I don't give a shit! Now look--

JOHN

All due respect, sir, my father's files on Holly Roberts--

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

Do not interrupt me! Don't do that.

JOHN

I'm sorry, sir.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

I've received two upsetting phone calls today.

(MORE)

CAPTAIN MARCHAND (CONT'D)

One from Maine State Police who say they received a phone call from a local business owner who's filed an official complaint about a cop impersonating a salesman scaring the hell out of all of his employees.

JOHN

That's not what happened--

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

I got a second call from Mr. Reginald Lund. Reggie says you've been throwing malicious accusations around that he might be somehow wrapped up in this whole thing.

JOHN

The case has been mishandled.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

Excuse me?

JOHN

I request permission to take lead investigative role.

The Captain almost laughs.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

Permission fucking denied. You got twenty four hours to file a report.

JOHN

Sir, I'm asking you--

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

I'm calling in the Bureau.

JOHN

What?

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

It's been a week. We both know the grim stats on kids missing beyond a week.

JOHN
You can't -- Why would you?
There's no known interstate
transportation -- if you just
let me, sir, give me some
more time--

CAPTAIN MARCHAND (CONT'D)
She is a girl of tender
years, 12 and under -- they
can monitor interstate travel
-- they'll share with us
intel on other kidnapping
situations --

CAPTAIN MARCHAND (CONT'D)
You had your time, John. No way.
Your job is done here. Understood?

A commotion outside the door. Shouting. It grows closer.
Captain goes to his door, opens it.

INT. HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Just down the hall officers try to keep back an irate man,
40's, who is shouting, looking into offices.

IRATE MAN
Kierstead! Kierstead, that fuck! I
wanna see him!

An officer rushes to the Captain--

OFFICER
It's the little girl's father.

IRATE MAN
Detective Kierstead?! Where is he?

DOUG
(to irate man)
Pete, don't.

John appears. He heads to the irate man, PETE (30's).

JOHN
Hey. I'm detective Kierstead.

Pete spots John, b-lines for him as officers try to grab him
but he just keeps coming. Even Captain intervenes. But its
too late -- POP!

Pete gets one solid punch into John's face before the dog
pile begins. John stumbles from the punch. He collapses to
the floor, holding his jaw.

INT. INTERROGATION ROOM - DAY

Doug and Pete and the Captain. Pete's handcuffed, his face showing the effects of what happens when you punch a cop in front of a bunch of other cops.

John walks in the room holding an ice pack over his jaw. Pete glances at him.

PETE

Sorry.

John waves it off.

PETE (CONT'D)

I never met the guy in person, okay? How was I supposed to know there's two detective Kierstead's in the same fuckin' town?

JOHN

I'm not from here.

PETE

Is anybody on this police force actually working this case? I mean, what the hell is going on up here? Nobody returns my calls. You won't even gimme an update--

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

Pete. We're doing our best. But you have to understand that this is still an active investigation. We simply cannot release info prematurely to--

PETE

I'm her father!

Can't argue with that.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND

Doug.

Doug steps over and uncuffs Pete.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND (CONT'D)

Now, Pete. Tell Detective Kierstead what you just told us, and what you told the other Detective Kierstead.

PETE

Can I smoke?

Captain nods. John tosses his lighter and his pack of smokes onto the table. Pete lights one, smokes, and goes on--

PETE (CONT'D)

Me and Cheyenne share custody of Holly. She stays here during the week, then it's weekends with me down in Newfields. Every Sunday night I drive all the way up here and I drop Holly off at Cheyenne's work.

JOHN

Denny's.

PETE

Yeah. Anyway, this last time I don't do that. Cheyenne, she comes all the way down and gets Holly herself.

JOHN

Is that unusual?

PETE

She's tried it before. Showing up Sunday mornings with some lame excuse to steal a half day of daddy-daughter time, you know? But this time she wasn't alone.

JOHN

Who was she with?

PETE

Some fuckin' douchebag driving a black Chrysler 300. Mass plates. I'd never seen the guy before.

John and Doug share a concerned glance.

PETE (CONT'D)

We were scheduled for a court hearing that week. Custody hearing. I was fightin' for full custody of Holly.

JOHN

Why's that?

PETE

You kiddin' me? Her mother's a dope fiend. Trippin' balls half the time.

(MORE)

PETE (CONT'D)
Shit, man, I swear her and this
goon were gonna run off with
Holly... My little girl... That was
the last time I ever saw her.

Pete turns to Captain.

PETE (CONT'D)
I called you guys. I fucking warned
ya's. But you didn't listen.

Pete wipes away a tear. He drops his head. He begins to cry.

PETE (CONT'D)
My baby girl. It's her birthday.
(looks up, tears)
Someone tell me where's my baby
girl?

John and the Captain trade a grim look.

EXT. DOVER POLICE PRECINCT - LATER

John and Doug exit the precinct and walk across the parking
lot. John cradles the box of Mackie's case files under one
arm, his free hand presses the ice pack to his sore jaw.

DOUG
These types of cases, I mean, they
can really get to you.

John shoots Doug a "how would you know?" look.

DOUG (CONT'D)
How about you join me and Trudy for
dinner tonight? It's good to
decompress sometimes, you know?

John smolders, shakes his head in disgust. He takes away the
ice pack and tosses it into a trash can.

JOHN
I got a report to write.

They arrive at John's car. John sets the box of files onto
the hood, digs into his pockets for his car keys.

JOHN (CONT'D)
You run the plate of that Chrysler?

DOUG
Came back clean. Guy's a drywall
contractor down in Quincy.

John finds his keys, unlocks his car and opens his door.

JOHN
Bullshit. He's a fucking drug
dealer.

DOUG
Maybe. Maybe not. How can I tell
that from a plate number?

JOHN
Forget it. I'll go find out myself.

Doug, frustrated--

DOUG
John. Guy's a nobody. OK? He's got
nothing to do with Holly. Just take
a damn break for a while, will ya?
(pause)
You gave it your best shot.

John takes offense. He slams his door shut.

JOHN
Excuse me? My best shot?

Doug, hesitant to say it--

DOUG
It's just... man, it's like...
You're dad passing away, and
like... whatever you and Cheyenne
had at one time, it's--

JOHN
So what?

DOUG
So... in another life Holly
could've been your daughter. And I
think that's making you not see
things so clearly.

Loaded pause.

JOHN
Fuck you.

DOUG
John, c'mon--

JOHN

Did you listen at all to what
Holly's dad just said in there? And
all that El Vaquero bullshit? You
got the father and her two best
friends telling us things that
nobody's ever heard of before.
Except one man.

John digs into the box of files, comes up with a fistful of
Mackie's papers and case photos. He holds them up.

JOHN (CONT'D)

He knew! Everything!

He balls the files up. Tosses them in the air.

JOHN (CONT'D)

And not one goddamn word!

Some passing officers stop. They watch John's outburst.

JOHN (CONT'D)

So either you're too loyal to
Mackie and his lackies to admit
that this case stinks, or maybe
your just too dumb of a cop to
realize it.

Doug is stung. But he takes the high road--

DOUG

I feel sorry for you, John. You
know? I really do.

Doug wants to say one more thing... but wisely doesn't. He
turns and heads back into the precinct.

John, instant regret, glances around at all the cop-eyes on
him. He opens his car door and throws the box of files in. He
then climbs in and slams the door, starts his car and peels
away.

EXT. DOVER - DAY

A late-autumn snow begins to fall over Dover.

A church organ plays. A choir joins in, singing a hymn, all
of it playing over...

EXT. MARINA - DAY

Blowing snow. Moored boats sway in the rough waters.

EXT. NATURE PRESERVE - COUNTRY ROAD - DAY

A trail diverts off into the forest. Same trail Holly and her friends travelled a week ago.

Pick-up trucks line the roadside. Through the trees, a group of search volunteers in safety vests head toward the trucks.

John's car pulls up.

EXT. PICK-UP TRUCKS - DAY

The volunteers remove their vests. Hope drained from their faces. They glance at John as he walks past them and down the wooded trail.

INT. CHURCH - DAY

Church service. The choir sings the hymn to a sparse congregation. Among the choir members is Trudy, hymnal book opened as she sings with conviction, almost a fervor.

EXT. NATURE PRESERVE - STONE FOUNDATION - DAY

Stoney remains of the 1600's settler's home where Holly's hobbyhorse was found. John sits here on the cold foundation, smoking a cigarette, looking out at the snowy forest.

EXT. CABIN - DAY

The cabin property and Reggie's newly-completed patio.

AT THE PATIO

Its foundation made of decorative lattice work. Between gaps in the lattice we catch glimpses of the bulkhead cellar door.

INT. CHURCH - DAY

Communion. Trudy in line to receive the Eucharist. She approaches the priest and presents her tongue to him, sensually. The priest lays the wafer on her tongue.

Trudy accepts the body of Christ, looking up at the priest, an odd touch of seduction in her eyes.

INT. CABIN CELLAR - NIGHT

The light snaps on showing the cellar. A handyman's man-cave. Reggie descends the stairs, shirtless, clutching a bottle of scotch. He takes a swig. Not his first of the night.

INT. SILVER DOLLAR SALOON - BATHROOM - NIGHT

The grungy bathroom at the Silver Dollar Saloon. Cheyenne in a cowboy hat studies her strung-out image in the mirror.

She opens her mouth, sticks out her tongue, and places a pill onto it. Ecstasy. She closes her mouth and swallows.

INT. CABIN CELLAR - NIGHT

Reggie at a workbench rummaging through a toolbox.

On a shelf are displayed a few photos of Mackie and Reggie -- hunting photos and wartime photos. Best buds, smiling.

Beside him on the bench sits a wicker basket, a small cushion placed inside it. On the cushion sits the bottle of scotch and a large hunting knife.

From the toolbox, Reggie comes up with a disposable needle and a vial of clear liquid -- near empty. He also finds a pill bottle containing pills of various sizes, colors.

He unwraps the needle, sticks its tip into the vial and fills the chamber with the leftover clear liquid.

He carefully sets the needle and pill bottle onto the cushion of the basket alongside the knife and the scotch.

INT. SILVER DOLLAR SALOON - NIGHT

Colorful lights flash across a crowded dance floor. Everyone's doing the two-step.

Except Cheyenne. She's rolling like hell on molly, dancing to a beat heard only in her head.

INT. CABIN CELLAR - NIGHT

Reggie in just his boxers now. He goes over to a locker and opens it and removes a furry grey costume -- a bunny suit. A very demented-looking bunny suit.

He climbs into the suit. Slips the hideous headpiece on.

He takes the wicker basket and goes over to a heavy steel door and opens it. Only darkness inside.

He steps into the darkness, shuts the door behind him as we see a wood-engraved plaque nailed above the door. It reads:

This Is Our Town

EXT. HARBOR DOCKS - NIGHT

The snow has stopped. Now a crisp moonlit night.

INT. JOHN'S RENTAL CAR - NIGHT

POV through the windshield as headlights illuminate the dock and the water, and the land on the other side -- State of Maine, no more than a few hundred feet away.

On the car's dash sits a newly-bought tray of baseballs, emptied of balls. The radio tuned again to sports talk:

RADIO HOST (V.O.)

*This isn't Emerson Spencer's first
time drafted. He was picked by
Toronto 41st overall out of high
school in 2020...*

John appears in the headlights. His coat pockets bulge with baseballs. He takes off his coat and hangs it on a dock pier.

RADIO HOST (V.O.)

*But he didn't sign, making him the
highest unsigned pick from the 2020
Draft...*

John begins to warm up, stretches out his arms, shoulders. He takes out a baseball and begins to run through pitch grips.

RADIO HOST (V.O.)

*... Great news for the Red Sox, who
now look very keen to invite
Spencer to Spring Training.*

John throws the ball. In the moonlight we see the ball plop into the harbor. Barely making it halfway across.

SERIES OF SHOTS: John throwing ball after ball, trying to hit the far shoreline, growing more tired after every throw.

One ball left. He backs up. He breaks into a run. At the dock's edge, he catapults the ball, hard.

He howls. Grabs for his shoulder. The ball soars but falls up short again.

He's pulled a ligament. He screams out in frustration. At so many things. He tries to walk off the pain. He kicks a trash can in anger.

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - LATER

Trudy and Doug at the dinner table, holding hands, plates of food untouched as Trudy says a blessing of thanks.

John walks in. Bruised cheek and favoring his injured arm. The good arm is carrying a 6-pack of beer.

Doug begins to eat, avoiding John's eyes. Trudy senses everyone's sour mood--

TRUDY

John? Are you hungry?

John walks away without a word and up to his room. Doug goes on eating. Trudy gets up from the table and goes after John.

22 YEARS AGO...

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - JOHN'S BEDROOM - DAY

Young John in his room, dressed in a dark suit, adjusting his tie in the mirror. A knock on the door and Mackie enters, also dressed in funeral attire.

MACKIE

Johnny. Let's go. We're gonna be late.

He sizes up his son. Senses the dark mood.

MACKIE (CONT'D)

I spoke to Cheyenne's mom. Cheyenne said she'll go. She's gonna be there with you.

John, still trying to get his tie just right, seems a million miles away.

MACKIE (CONT'D)

John?

John stops fidgeting with his tie. He stares at himself in the mirror. His hands begin to tremble. His breathing goes hard. Panic sets in.

MACKIE (CONT'D)

Johnny?

John claws at his tie, gasping for air.

YOUNG JOHN

No! Oh fuck! No! No, no, no!

MACKIE (CONT'D)

Jesus, John, it's okay. Hey, calm down.

Young John rips off his tie. His legs give out and he almost collapses. He stops himself by clutching the dresser.

Mackie goes over and helps John up. He sits him onto the bed.

MACKIE (CONT'D)

Sit down.

John struggles in his father's arms. Mackie tries to calm him. He squares John's shoulders, looks him dead in the eye.

MACKIE (CONT'D)

John, hey. It's over. Okay? It's all over. Look, all we gotta do is go to this funeral, and then everything is behind us. Alright?

John pushes Mackie away.

YOUNG JOHN

Get out.

MACKIE

You'll go back to school, then spring training. You'll feel back to normal in no time. Now trust me.

Mackie moves in for a hug. Young John recoils.

YOUNG JOHN

Fuck you!

Mackie, stunned--

MACKIE

What?

YOUNG JOHN

You think I'm ever gonna play
baseball after this?!

Without warning, Mackie's big powerful hand grabs John's
throat, squeezing.

MACKIE

You fucking ungrateful shit!

John struggles, but can't break free. Mackie's grip hardens.

MACKIE (CONT'D)

This family has done nothing but
sacrifice for you! Your poor dead
mother. You wanna disappoint her?!

YOUNG TRUDY (O.S.)

... Dad?

Young Trudy in a black dress stands at the open door. Mackie
lets go of Young John. Mackie half turns to his daughter.

MACKIE

Trudy. Get in the car, honey.

Mackie composes himself. He address his son--

MACKIE (CONT'D)

When you're ready...

He tosses a wad of dollar bills onto the bed.

MACKIE (CONT'D)

... you can take a cab to the
church.

Mackie walks out. Trudy lingers in the doorway, staring in at
her older brother sitting on the bed, rubbing his throat.
Finally, she turns and walks away.

PRESENT --

INT. JOHN'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

John sits by the open window, smoking a cigarette. He has a
beer in his hand and a cold compress over his shoulder.

Knock on the door. It's Trudy.

TRUDY
Hey. Sure you don't want some food?

JOHN
I'm sure.

She steps into the room.

TRUDY
I see we're smoking in the house
now?

John, not in the mood, flicks the butt out the window. He
takes a drink of his beer.

TRUDY (CONT'D)
What happened to your shoulder?

JOHN
Nothing.

TRUDY
Doug told me what happened at the
police station today, with you off
the case and--

JOHN
Who gives a shit, Trudy? Seriously.

Trudy, fed up, turns and leaves. She comes back.

TRUDY
You know, Doug is trying his best.
Everyone here is just trying their
best. So you really didn't need to
go and shit on him like that.

John, sarcastically, shouts down to Doug--

JOHN
Sorry, Doug!

INT. KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

With Doug at the table, eating.

JOHN (O.S.)
You're a very good police officer!

Doug pauses mid-bite, looks up from his food.

INT. JOHN'S BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS

John looks to his sister.

JOHN
Happy?

TRUDY
You know what really bugs me? That
you never questioned Cheyenne.

JOHN
About what?

TRUDY
About what? John, all of New
Hampshire is out looking for Holly.
Except her own mother. Doesn't that
strike you as a little odd?

JOHN
It's over, Tru. The kid's gone.
Besides, I won't be sticking around
much longer. I'm going back to L.A.

TRUDY
Why do you hate this place so much?

JOHN
The real question is why do you
pretend to love this place?

Pause. Trudy shakes her head in disgust.

TRUDY
You're unbelievable.

She turns to go, but before she can get too far--

JOHN
What the fuck do you got against
her, anyway?

She turns back.

TRUDY
Who? Cheyenne? I do not--

JOHN
You never liked her.

TRUDY
John--

JOHN

You never even tried to like her.

TRUDY

That is so not true! I never liked the way dad treated her.

JOHN

What the hell's that supposed to mean?

TRUDY

She's a single black mother--

JOHN

Hey!

John stands. Gets in Trudy's face.

JOHN (CONT'D)

You better watch what you say!

TRUDY

With a drug problem that dad always looked the other way on!

JOHN (CONT'D)

Get out.

TRUDY

You know how many times she's been arrested in the past two years?

JOHN

I said get out.

TRUDY

Twelve! Never reprimanded. Never charged. Never even saw the inside of a jail cell. Maybe she would've been better off in there. Maybe Holly would've been better off.

JOHN

Jesus. Why don't you just say it?

TRUDY

Say what?

JOHN

You were always jealous of Cheyenne and Holly, and how good dad treated them. Like they were his own.

Trudy simmers. She reloads--

TRUDY
Cheyenne never had to grow up,
John... And neither did you.

John has no answer. He storms past Trudy and out of the room.

EXT. DOVER - LATE NIGHT

Shots of late-night, snow-covered Dover.

EXT. DENNYS - LATE NIGHT

Denny's. Through the diner window we see John sitting in a booth eating a late night breakfast, alone.

INT. DENNYS - LATER

John at the cash, paying his bill. He says something to the hostess. She replies with a shrug and a shake of her head.

INT./EXT. JOHN'S CAR/STREETS OF DOVER - LATER

John drives through the slush-layered streets.

From his recorded interview with Ricardo...

RICARDO
*Two other men. Alberto Gomez and
Raymond Olsen.*

JOHN
*Alberto and Raymond... Tell me
more.*

RICARDO
*Raymond. He no longer works with
us. They fired him... But I still
see him sometimes, at the bar.*

JOHN
Which bar?

RICARDO
The Silver Dollar Saloon.

EXT. SILVER DOLLAR SALOON - LATE NIGHT

Silver Dollar Saloon. Its marquee reads: *Open Mic Nite.*

John's car pulls up and parks.

INT. SILVER DOLLAR SALOON - LATE NIGHT

John enters to the sights and sounds of cowboys and cowgirls, lots of leather and American beer. Up on a small stage, a man in a cowboy get-up sings '*Rhinestone Cowboy*'.

John saddles up to the bar. Orders a beer from the bartender, then leans in to him...

JOHN

I'm supposed to meet a guy here.
Name's Raymond Olsen. See him
around at all?

BARTENDER

Ray? Nah. Haven't seen him since,
jeez, a week ago?

JOHN

Oh?

BARTENDER

Strange. Guy never misses open mic.

JOHN

Yeah?

Bartender produces from under the bar a small cardboard box containing about a dozen self-produced CD's in their cases.

BARTENDER

He leaves these here. Take one if
you want.

John lifts out a CD. A selfie of Raymond on the front cover--hokey smile, decked out in a spiffy cowboy outfit with a guitar. He's clearly mentally disabled. Though not profound.

JOHN

Any good?

BARTENDER

(sarcastic)

Yeah. The next Hank Williams.

Bartender walks off, leaving John with Raymond's box of CD's. John tries to pop open a case to look inside, but--

CHEYENNE (O.S.)

Heeeeerrrrre's Johnny!

Cheyenne. She comes at him from behind and throws her arms around him. John pockets the CD case and half-turns and sees it's her.

He pulls her off of him. She plops herself onto a bar stool. She's still rolling on molly. John looks at her, contemptuously.

CHEYENNE (CONT'D)
What?

JOHN
Shouldn't you be at work?

Buzz-kill.

CHEYENNE
What are you? A cop?

Pause. She realizes, laughs hysterically.

CHEYENNE (CONT'D)
Oh! I am so sorry, officer.

She keeps laughing. John suddenly yanks her off the barstool and practically drags her toward the exit.

CHEYENNE (CONT'D)
Hey!

EXT. SILVER DOLLAR SALOON

Alleyway of the Silver Dollar. The side door bursts open and Cheyenne spills out, followed by John.

CHEYENNE
The fuck is your problem, man?

John keeps pulling her along down the alleyway.

INT. CAR - CONTINUOUS

POV: unseen driver, watching things escalate in the alley.

EXT. SILVER DOLLAR - CONTINUOUS

CHEYENNE
Let go of me!

JOHN
Shut up. We're just going to my car
for a minute.

CHEYENNE
I swear I'll scream 'rape'.

Cheyenne squirms, tries to run. John grabs her, pins her to the wall.

JOHN
No one else in town seems to be
concerned with reeling you in. Now
I wanna know why.

CHEYENNE
I said let me go.

JOHN
Do you even give a shit that she's
gone?

CHEYENNE
She's not gone. She's coming back,
and then everything will be fine.
So leave me alone.

She breaks free, goes to flee. John yanks her back again.

INT. CAR - CONTINUOUS

The driver is the Hispanic and we're in the Chrysler 300. He pops open his console and takes out his gun. He gets out of the car.

EXT. SILVER DOLLAR - CONTINUOUS

Cheyenne is practically pinned to the wall by John.

JOHN
Know how many of these cases I've
worked? The chances of Holly just
walking through your front door...
Jesus, Chey, go play the Powerball
if you want better odds.
(pause)
Tell me what's going on.

CHEYENNE
Nothing is going on.

JOHN

What was Mackie hiding? What was he up to?

CHEYENNE

Mackie was doing a helluva lot more than you are.

JOHN

I'm off the case. It's the FBI's now. Whatever you and Mackie were doing, they're gonna find out.

CHEYENNE

(with venom)

What'd you do? Quit?

Barrel of a gun touches John's head. John freezes.

HISPANIC (O.S.)

Let her go, holmes.

John releases Cheyenne.

CHEYENNE

O'Shea. Baby. Don't. He's a friend.

O'SHEA roughs up John, shoves him up against the wall.

CHEYENNE (CONT'D)

This is John. The guy I told you about.

O'SHEA

The cop from L.A.? Oh yeah? What's your Cali ass doing snooping this far east?

CHEYENNE

O'Shea, stop.

JOHN

California dreamin'.

In a flash, John disarms O'Shea of his weapon and has him on his knees about to snap his arm in half. Cheyenne screams.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Everyone get the fuck in my car.

INT. JOHN'S CAR - LATE NIGHT

John in the driver's seat. Cheyenne next to him. O'Shea sits in back, a bit emasculated.

John ejects the clip from O'Shea's gun, empties the bullets into his hand, pockets them. He tosses the gun out the window into the snow.

O'SHEA

What the fuck?!

John auto-locks all the doors.

JOHN

You can have it back when we're finished.

O'SHEA

(to Cheyenne)

You best tell your friend he better watch his step.

JOHN

Hey, asshole. Her friend is still a member of law enforcement. And as such, her friend can still haul your worthless Cheech ass in for assault with a weapon on an off-duty police officer. Got that?

O'Shea sits back, silent.

CHEYENNE

Why are you not working Holly's case anymore?

O'SHEA

Cuz cops don't give a fuck, that's why.

JOHN

I didn't quit.

CHEYENNE

You gotta stay on the case, John.

(she thinks)

I'll hire you.

(turns to O'Shea)

Baby, give him some money.

(to John)

C'mon. You don't understand, it's like--

JOHN

You know what I don't understand?
Every time the music stops in this
sick musical chairs, you two always
seem to be the ones left standing?
Now why is that?

O'SHEA

All I'm tryin' to do is help her
forget for a moment about this hell
she's in.

JOHN

Oh, is that so?

O'SHEA

Look, I know a lot of fucked up
dudes who know a lotta fucked up
dudes. If you know what I'm sayin'?

JOHN

You saying you heard something?

O'SHEA

Crickets. I ain't proud to say it,
but if this was some kinda heinous
pedo underground shit, I would've
heard about it by now.

Cheyenne gives O'Shea a pleading look. O'Shea softens, sighs--

O'SHEA (CONT'D)

Except for that old Army cat.

JOHN

Army cat? What army cat?

O'SHEA

Straight-up local square. Been
hittin me up every couple days. And
for serious gear.

CHEYENNE

It's Reggie, John.

O'SHEA

Him and his cop buddy.

John to Cheyenne. She nods.

CHEYENNE

Mackie.

O'SHEA

They came to me. Yo, I had to give it up. Only way I was able to stay out of the equation.

JOHN

They were buying drugs? From you? Mackie and Reggie?

O'SHEA

Wasn't no transaction. It was a mutha-fuckin' salt and pepper shakedown. Every time. Pullin' me over. Gangbustin' my home and shit.

JOHN

What'd they ask for?

O'SHEA

More like what'd they rob. Like I said, crazy cocktail shit. High-grade. Pharmaceutical. Government. Military. You name it.

(pause)

When I told 'em it'll take a while, they got real pissed. Said they're gonna pin Holly all on me.

JOHN

Are you sure about all this?

O'SHEA

Nah, we're just all livin' in the mutherfuckin' Matrix. Of course I'm sure.

JOHN

(to Cheyenne)

Why didn't you tell anyone?

O'SHEA

I thought you were a cop. Didn't you see Serpico? Sucka got shot in the face, yo! And I don't wanna have to move to no Switzerland.

Cheyenne: It's unclear whether she's going to cry or be sick. Crying wins out.

CHEYENNE

I know I could've been a better mom. God, I know.

(crying intensifies)

I'm so sorry.

(MORE)

CHEYENNE (CONT'D)

You gotta find her, John. I mean,
this'll be it for me. I'm going
clean. NA, AA, fucking born again,
whatever it takes...

(looks to John)

You gotta find her... please.

John can't meet her gaze. He opens the door, reaches into the snow and picks up the gun and hands it to O'Shea.

JOHN

Take her home.

O'Shea takes the gun. He gets out and goes around to the front and helps Cheyenne out of the car.

O'SHEA

C'mon, babe. Let's go.

Cheyenne gives John one more look, pleading, desperate, and then gets out and walks away, leaving John all alone. His thoughts race in all directions.

INT./EXT. JOHN'S CAR/MARINA - NIGHT

The night is very cold. John's parked at the marina, looking out at the bay.

He turns the car on for some heat. He stuffs his hands into his coat pockets for extra warmth.

His hand feels something. He comes up with Raymond's CD case.

He considers it a moment, tosses it onto the passenger seat.

A beat.

He glances down to the case. He picks it up and opens it...

On the front of the disc, scrawled in black marker is the title of Raymond's album: **El Vaquero.**

A revelation slams into John. El vaquero. He shoves his car into gear, mashes the gas pedal, and peels away.

The Rolling Stones, "Gimmie Shelter" begins to play over...

EXT. FERRY - DAWN

The mainland. A ferry laborer guides a line of waiting vehicles onto the ferry.

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - DAWN

Mackie's den. Decorating the walls are Mackie's police commendations, awards, and military medals.

Across the room stands a solid oak gun cabinet. It's doors opened... A hunting rifle is missing...

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - BEDROOM - DAWN

Trudy in bed, wide awake. Doug fast asleep next to her.

Trudy stares off at the window and the first light of dawn breaking through the curtains.

The alarm clock goes off. Doug stirs.

INT. CABIN CELLAR - DAWN

The heavy metal door. Padlocked. "Gimmie Shelter", now muffled, is clearly coming from somewhere in the cabin.

On the workbench: used needles and a few empty vials. The locker is wide open. The bunny suit hanging there.

INT. JOHN'S CAR - CONTINUOUS

Raymond's *El Vaquero* album still on the passenger seat. Next to it sits an open box of ammunition. Some shells missing.

EXT. CABIN - DAWN

The cabin. The property. John appears cutting across the snowy open field with his dad's rifle in hand.

EXT. BACK PATIO - CABIN - DAWN

John reaches the cabin's back door. He turns the doorknob. Locked. He fishes the keys out of his pocket, sticks the key in the lock. Key won't turn.

He tries again. Notta. He inspects the door knob and the deadbolt. Brand new. Locks have been changed.

John steps back, raises a leg and boots the door in.

INT. CABIN - KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

John enters. Takes in the mess -- dishes piled in the sink. Take-out containers and beer bottles litter the table.

LIVING ROOM

"Gimmie Shelter" blasts from stereo speakers. The room itself in disarray. More beer cans and take-out boxes. Dirty laundry is strewn about, some of it spotted heavy with blood.

John appears, rifle at the ready. He sees the bloody clothes, yet he remains cop-calm. But behind the calm he's amped.

He goes to the stereo and shuts off the music. He calls out:

JOHN

Reggie?

His phone buzzes a text. He checks it.

From O'Shea: *Army cat just took more gear.*

John types back: *When?*

O'Shea: *Half-hour ago.*

John puts his phone away and starts checking the rest of the cabin. Room by room. Very tactical.

HALLWAY

John moves down the hallway.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Reggie? Are you here?

A MOAN is heard. Faint. Very eerie. Coming from somewhere in the cabin. John stops.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Hello?

Another moan. Definitely a man's. John listens. His gaze shifts to the floor beneath his feet. His focus turns to the end of the hallway and the cellar door.

INT. CELLAR - MOMENTS LATER

The light snaps on and John comes down the stairs. Nobody here. He moves to the workbench, sees the vials, the needles. The bunny suit in the locker.

That moan again. Then a cry. John looks to the source: the door to the old furnace room. Padlocked.

JOHN
Raymond? Raymond Olsen?

Another bellowing cry.

John lays his rifle on the workbench, grabs a sledgehammer. He swings it into the padlock with a loud CLANK!

INT. REGGIE'S TRUCK - CONTINUOUS

Reggie drives down the private cabin road, one hand on the wheel, the other holds a bit of cocaine in the crook of his thumb. He brings it up to his nose and snorts it.

He comes around a bend, sees John's car parked just up ahead. He pulls in behind and idles.

He eyes John's car. He shuts his truck off.

EXT. JOHN'S CAR - CONTINUOUS

Reggie approaches, peeks in John's front seat. Sees the box of ammunition. He glances down the road to the cabin.

He walks back to his truck, opens his door, and grabs his hunting rifle off the rack.

INT. CELLAR - CONTINUOUS

John swings the sledgehammer one more time, obliterating the lock off the door. He picks up his rifle, levels at the furnace door. With his free hand he yanks the door open...

Darkness. Next to him hangs a flashlight. He grabs it.

INT. FURNACE ROOM - CONTINUOUS

John silhouetted in the doorway. He flicks on the flashlight to reveal in the middle of the room...

John's POV: A MAN IN A CHAIR. Black canvas bag over his head. Wrists bound to the chair.

John cautiously steps into the room. Rifle aimed at the man.

JOHN
Raymond Olsen?

The man makes a guttural noise. He cries.

John steps over to the man. He has a work uniform on, laborers clothes -- blue collar shirt, blue pants.

Down the front of man's shirt, from underneath the canvas bag, are dried-up rivulets of blood and pus and Lord knows what else.

John sweeps the flashlight down to the floor. The man is barefoot. Surrounding his feet is a stagnant puddle of urine and more blood.

John brings the light back up to the man, glimpsing a name stitched into the man's work shirt. John steps closer, squints to read the name through all the crusted fluids...

JOHN (CONT'D)

Alberto.

The man stays silent. He begins to tremble. John finds the room's light switch. He flicks it on.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Alberto, it's OK. I'm not going to hurt you. I'm going to take this bag off your head now, okay?

John pulls the bag off, revealing ALBERTO GOMEZ, blood-soaked face grotesque with a horror of sores and cuts. A rag has been stuffed into his mouth.

One eye is swollen shut. The other... well, there isn't one -- as if scooped out with a melon baller.

John jerks back, almost stumbles. He lowers the rifle.

JOHN (CONT'D)

... Jesus.

Alberto trembles with shock and terror. John removes the rag from Alberto's mouth. Alberto's lips quiver. He whispers...

ALBERTO

... Diablo... Diablo...

Alberto SCREAMS. Blood curdling.

EXT. CABIN PROPERTY - CONTINUOUS

Alberto's scream is heard.

INT. FURNACE ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Alberto's expression returns to a vacant trauma, as John quickly digs out his cell phone, goes to dial 911.

From behind comes the sound of a Remington pump-action rifle. John freezes.

REGGIE (O.S.)
You're way outta your jurisdiction,
John.

John raises his hands. He slowly turns to face a coked-out Reggie brandishing his shotgun.

REGGIE (CONT'D)
Your phone.

John tosses his phone. Reggie picks it up and pockets it.

JOHN
What are you doing, Reggie?

REGGIE
Now put the gun down.

JOHN
You got the wrong guy.

REGGIE
Drop the gun, John.

JOHN
This is not El Vaquero.

REGGIE
Jesus Christ, just drop your gun.

JOHN
El Vaquero is a man named Raymond Olsen. You got the wrong guy.

REGGIE
This scumbag beaner. He raped Holly. He already confessed.

JOHN
Was that before you gouged his eye out or after?

REGGIE
I'm givin' you a chance here, Johnny.

(MORE)

REGGIE (CONT'D)
Drop the fucking gun, go on back to
L.A., and let me handle this.

John doesn't comply. He begins to slowly raise his rifle.

REGGIE (CONT'D)
You dumb motherfucker. Drop that
fucking gun!

John, rifle fully levelled at Reggie.

JOHN
You got the wrong guy. This isn't
El Vaquero. This isn't right.

REGGIE
You're forcing my hand here, John!

JOHN
This is my property. I want you to
turn around and leave. Or I'll be
forced to defend myself.

REGGIE
Your father was my buddy. My man!
In his last moments, we were
together... me and him... in the
goddamn fucking ambulance!
(pause)
I made him a promise: that I'd
finish what we started. This is our
town.

JOHN
It's not right.

REGGIE
Fuck that! What do you know about
what's right?! Your father not
turning you in 20 years ago? Was
that right? You're goddamn right it
was! Now stand down, soldier!

JOHN
Drop your weapon, Reggie.

REGGIE
I ain't breakin' my promise! May
the Lord be my witness, you've made
your choice, Detective.

Reggie takes aim at John's head.

JOHN

No!

Reggie pulls the trigger. John kicks the heavy furnace room door closed, shielding the Remington's spray of buckshot.

The gun blast is EAR-SPLITTING. Alberto screams. John stays composed. He pops out of the room and returns fire--

BOOM! Another ear-splitter.

A howl from Reggie. John ducks back into the room, glances to Alberto -- in his tortured state it's tough to tell if he's been hit.

A commotion upstairs, things falling, breaking. A door being thrown open. Then nothing but Alberto's wails.

John turns and races out of the room after Reggie.

INT. CABIN HALLWAY - CONTINUOUS

Leading with his gun, John comes out of the cellar. Blood trails the hallway. John follows it.

EXT. CABIN - CONTINUOUS

Blood smears the back door that's barely being held together by its hinges. John steps out and onto the patio, pauses.

Ahead of him the blood trail thickens, stretching across the snowy property and into the forest.

EXT. FOREST - MOMENTS LATER

John in the woods. He climbs up a small hill. Crests it. On the other side he sees:

Reggie. Sitting propped against a tree, head leaned back, clutching his rifle on his lap. His chest and shoulder perforated by John's buckshot.

WITH REGGIE

As John approaches, rifle aimed squarely at Reggie--

REGGIE

Mackie looked after that little
girl... like she was his own...
(smiles)

(MORE)

REGGIE (CONT'D)
Christmas gifts, birthday
parties... Days at the beach.

JOHN
Toss the gun.

Reggie tosses the rifle off to his side. He winces in pain. He struggles for air. Lungs collapsing from buckshot.

REGGIE
You know Cheyenne never brought
Holly to church? Not once. No first
communion. No confession. Never
even baptized. Believe that?

He coughs blood. Wipes his mouth of it. His face greys. He's fading fast.

JOHN
Let me make a call.

Reggie smiles, shakes his head 'no'.

REGGIE
Nah... You know what happens if you
don't get baptized? Devil finds
you. You stick out like a sore
thumb. Mackie wanted to change
that. Started takin' Holly to
Sunday service. Him and Trudy...

An odd peace falls over Reggie. He shuts his eyes.

REGGIE (CONT'D)
In this topsy-turvy world... you
gotta have God on your team...

He opens his eyes, looks up at John standing over him. He takes one last breath, and then he's gone.

John stands there, looking down at Reggie as a light snow begins to fall over the forest.

A phone rings... In Reggie's pocket. John's ringtone. John cautiously goes for the phone, takes it out, never taking his eyes or gun off Reggie.

John's POV: his cell. Caller ID: Doug. John answers.

JOHN
Doug...

DOUG (ON PHONE)
John. They they found Holly's body.

JOHN

What?

DOUG (ON PHONE)

Washed up on the bay this morning.

John sinks. Every fiber of his being sinks. He looks over at the lifeless Reggie.

DOUG (ON PHONE) (CONT'D)

I'm sorry, John. We really tried.

JOHN

Does Cheyenne--

DOUG (ON PHONE)

No. I was gonna--

JOHN

Don't... Let me do it.

EXT. CABIN - DAY

An air ambulance helicopter roars in over the treetops, emerging onto the open field of the cabin property. Its rotor wash kicks up a blizzard of snow.

John stands at the edge of the property, numbly smoking a cigarette and watching Reggie being carried by EMS out of the forest in a bodybag.

Alberto, on mobile life support, is quickly lifted into the air ambulance.

John is questioned by officers, who write down his every word. They shake hands. John tosses his cigarette away. He turns and walks off toward the road.

EXT. CHEYENNE'S TOWNHOUSE - DAY

John's car pulls up outside the townhouse. Followed by a Dover PD cruiser. John climbs out of his car and heads toward Cheyenne's front door.

Doug gets out of his cruiser but stays behind, watching.

EXT. CHEYENNE'S FRONT DOOR - DAY

John. Hesitant. Finally, he knocks.

INT. CHEYENNE'S FRONT DOOR - DAY

Cheyenne opens her door. She sees John. She instantly knows. An unspoken moment between them.

John struggles, then breaks the news.

A moment...

Cheyenne collapses. John catches her before the fall, into his arms. He remains stoic. She is in hysterics.

PASSAGE OF TIME SEQUENCE...

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - JOHN'S BEDROOM - NIGHT

John sits in a chair, heavy mood. Beer in one hand, a baseball in the other. Several empty beer cans clutter the window sill. He absently cycles through pitch grips.

INT. FUNERAL PARLOR - DAY

Holly's wake. A small framed portrait of Holly stands on an equally small casket. The room is jam-packed. John is here. As is Doug, Captain Marchand, and many others.

Cheyenne is up front in a black dress next to a glum O'Shea in a dark suit. Cheyenne is lost, part of her has died, and without anymore tears to shed for it.

INT. HOSPITAL ROOM - DAY

Alberto Gomez, comatose in a hospital bed, hooked up to a crowd of wires, tubes, and ventilators.

INT. MORTUARY - DAY

A bright, sterile room. The preparation room. Alone on a metal table sits a bronze urn, engraved with:

Reginald Jason Lund - 1955-2023

INT. FUNERAL PARLOR - DAY

As Holly's mourners file out of the viewing room, Captain Marchand approaches John.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
Detective.

JOHN
Captain.

The men walk and talk.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
Three funerals in two weeks. How
are you holding up?

JOHN
I shouldn't complain, considering
with the ground frozen, Cheyenne
has to wait five long months just
to bury her daughter.

Captain nods.

JOHN (CONT'D)
How's Gomez?

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
Amazingly enough, looks like he'll
pull through. Of course, he'll be
extradited back to Mexico.

EXT. FUNERAL PARLOR - CONTINUOUS

The two men exit the parlor.

JOHN
Extradited?

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
Turns out Reginald Lund was right.

JOHN
How do you figure that?

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
Gomez was a registered sex
offender. Multiple rapes of minors
back in Mexico City. Escaped
custody six months ago. I guess he
fled as far north as he could get.

JOHN
So Reggie got his El Vaquero.

John and the Captain look out at the mourners returning to
their cars. Cheyenne is led to the Chrysler 300 by O'Shea.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
Just not the right vaquero.

JOHN
Raymond Olsen?

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
It's still an open case. Bureau is
investigating. As are we.

John watches Cheyenne in the 300's passenger seat. She looks
out the window at John.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND (O.S.) (CONT'D)
But with no known fixed address, we
just haven't had any promising
leads, aside from occasional
sightings at homeless shelters,
churches. But we'll find him.

The 300 pulls away. John watches it until it disappears.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND (O.S.) (CONT'D)
John?

John looks to the Captain.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND (CONT'D)
Look, despite our obvious
differences in methodology, I want
to thank you for everything that
you've done.

Captain places his hand onto John's shoulder, reassuringly.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND (CONT'D)
Your father would be very proud of
you, John. Understand me?

John nods. Looks away. Knowing he'll keep the truth of his
father's involvement forever a secret.

The Captain and John part ways.

Over filtered rings...

EXT. APARTMENT BUILDING - MORNING

Low-income housing. The rings go on, until--

DISPATCH (ON PHONE)
Good morning, Dover Police
Department, how may we help you?

INT. LOW INCOME UNIT - BATHROOM - MORNING

RAYMOND OLSEN (mid-40's) in front of his bathroom mirror. Fresh from the shower, towel at his waist. He meticulously combs his hair. Clearly, he has Down Syndrome.

His voice comes in, harboring a speech deficit -- his words stuttering and slow to form...

RAYMOND (V.O.)
I would like to speak to Federal
agents in charge of the Holly
Roberts investigation.

He puts down his comb. He studies his reflection.

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - BEDROOM - MORNING

Trudy in her bedroom, kneeling bed-side, a rosary wrapped around her hands as she recites the Hail Mary...

TRUDY
Hail Mary, full of grace, the Lord
is with thee...

INT. LOW INCOME UNIT - BATHROOM - MORNING

Raymond clips his fingernails...

BEDROOM

Raymond dresses himself. Conservative church wear. Dockers, loafers, a white button-up dress shirt.

TRUDY (O.S.)
Blessed are thou among women, and
blessed is the fruit of thy womb,
Jesus...

KITCHEN

A neatly kept kitchen. Raymond at the table eating a breakfast of grapefruit and coffee.

TRUDY (O.S.) (CONT'D)
Holy Mary, mother of God, pray for
our sinners, now and at the hour of
our death. Amen.

LIVING ROOM

Raymond walks into his small, empty living room, over to a far wall where he has built a makeshift SHRINE:

Two large paintings hung side by side on the wall. One is of Jesus. The other, a grotesque rendition of Lucifer.

Beneath these paintings hangs a small portrait of Holly.

Xmas lights have been strung around the shrine. Raymond plugs them in. The lights come on, flashing multi-colors.

Raymond kneels before the shrine. He makes the sign of the cross, clasps his hands in prayer, and begins to recite...

RAYMOND

Hail Mary, full of grace, the Lord
is with thee...

INT. KIERSTEAD HOME - BEDROOM - CONTINUOUS

Trudy bedside with the rosary--

TRUDY

Blessed are thou among women, and
blessed is the fruit of thy womb,
Jesus...

INT. RAYMOND'S LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Raymond with his eyes closed. His words matching Trudy's--

RAYMOND/TRUDY

Holy Mary, mother of God, pray for
our sinners, now and at the hour of
our death. Amen.

Once more...

RAYMOND/TRUDY (CONT'D)

Hail Mary, full of grace, the Lord
is with thee...

EXT. LOW INCOME HOUSING - CONTINUOUS

Front lawn of the apartment building. Creeping into frame from behind us is a single file of about a dozen heavily-armed men donning FBI jackets.

RAYMOND/TRUDY
Blessed are thou among women, and
blessed is the fruit of thy womb,
Jesus...

INT. LOW INCOME HOUSING - HALLWAY - MORNING

The Federal agents enter the hallway, swiftly yet cautiously.
They step up to unit 204. Flank the door. Guns at the ready.

RAYMOND/TRUDY
Holy Mary, mother of God, pray for
our sinners...

Lead agent nods to another agent who hoists a battering ram.
The other agents step back. Everyone poised. Totally juiced.

RAYMOND/TRUDY (CONT'D)
... now and at the hour of our
death...

The battering ram winds up, and....

RAYMOND/TRUDY (CONT'D)
... Amen.

BOOM! Raymond's front door splinters and drops. The agents
storm into the unit.

INT. RAYMOND'S LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Agents descend onto Raymond, who doesn't even budge. He was
expecting this. Feds shout orders at Raymond. "Hands up!"
"Get down!" "On the floor!".

Raymond is slammed to the floor, face first. He's handcuffed.
Amid the chaos, he repeats the final word of prayer...

RAYMOND
Amen... Amen... Amen...

INT. AIRPORT BAR - DAY

John at an airport bar with his carry-on and a one-way ticket
back to L.A. He sips his drink. The TV above the bar grabs
his attention. Breaking newscast --

ANCHOR WOMAN

Breaking news out of Dover this morning: A major break in the case of Holly Roberts, the missing Dover girl whose body was discovered last week washed ashore along the Piscataqua River....

ON TV

Anchor woman at her desk, the graphic at her shoulder is a picture of smiling Holly next to a mugshot of Raymond.

ANCHOR WOMAN (CONT'D)

...FBI officials have now confirmed evidence from Internet chat rooms and cell phone records, connecting local man, Raymond Olsen, to the kidnapping and murder of Holly. Mr. Olsen is currently in Federal custody and is awaiting trial pending a psychological evaluation. He has pleaded not guilty.

John sets down his drink. Slight relief washes over him. His phone rings. It's Doug. John answers.

JOHN

Doug. I just heard. Ya got him.

Doug's voice is shaky, nervous--

DOUG

Yeah... Um, look, John...
(clears throat)
Uh... Do you, uh... Have you seen Trudy?

INT. DOVER POLICE PRECINCT - DAY

John bursts through the precinct doors and past the front desk officer.

JOHN

Where is he?

OFFICER

Room Two. He's still talking.

INT. HALLWAY - DAY

An upset Doug paces outside Interview Room Two. John enters the hallway. Doug sees John.

DOUG
He just started spewing all this
shit about Trudy. Why would he say
that, John?

JOHN
Calm down. It's OK.

DOUG
Why would he say those things?

JOHN
I don't know. But just -- we'll
figure it out. OK? Get outta here
for a while. Go take a break.

DOUG
But, John--

JOHN
Get a coffee, Doug. Go.

John enters the Interview Room. Doug lingers a beat, hesitates, then leaves.

INT. OBSERVATION ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Captain Marchand watches through a two-way mirror. On the other side, Federal Agents grill a frightened Raymond. John enters the observation room. Captain looks to him.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
I dunno where he's getting this
stuff, but he seems convinced.

John looks in at Raymond and the Feds.

INT. INTERROGATION ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Raymond sits with a mixed expression of fear and annoyance. A FEDERAL AGENT looms over him.

FEDERAL AGENT
You're not being honest with us,
Raymond. Time to man-up, dude.

RAYMOND

It's OK. She said it's OK. She said I would be doing the Lord's work. I don't wanna make Him angry. No. It was OK. I was doing the Lord's work.

FEDERAL AGENT

Yeah, we know Trudy was helping you, Raymond. But you're not answering the fucking question: Why did you kill Holly? Why did you do it, Raymond?

RAYMOND

No! I was doing the Lord's work!

FEDERAL AGENT

Fuck that. You came to Trudy for help. You came to the church for help. You lost your job. You fucked up and now you got zero prospects. Shit, man, you got no money. Barely a home. Tell me...

(leans in to Raymond)

Who's gonna wanna hire a retard?

Raymond furrows, offended.

FEDERAL AGENT (CONT'D)

You sought counsel. But it wasn't enough. And when you felt that God turned his back on you, you went off. Didn't you? You got revenge.

RAYMOND

No. What? No... I gave her back. I gave Holly back to Trudy. Everything was OK.

WITH JOHN

Stunned.

FEDERAL AGENT

Fuck you, you gave her back. You drowned her in the Bay. How many times we gotta go over that?

(pause)

What happened before you killed her?

BACK WITH RAYMOND

RAYMOND
I did not do that.

FEDERAL AGENT
You ask for a kiss?

RAYMOND
No.

FEDERAL AGENT
She say no?

RAYMOND
No.

FEDERAL AGENT
She laugh at you?

RAYMOND
No. I wanna go home.

FEDERAL AGENT
She mocked you, didn't she? Didn't
wanna kiss the retard. Get retard
cooties. Yuck! Bleh!

RAYMOND
I wanna go home now. I wanna play
my guitar.

FEDERAL AGENT
You can't go home, Raymond. I'm
afraid home no longer exists for
you. Time to play a different tune.
How 'bout twenty five to life? You
know that one?

RAYMOND
Stop it!

INT. OBSERVATION ROOM - CONTINUOUS

John and Captain stare in at Raymond.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
I'm gonna assume you know nothing
about any of this.

JOHN
Of course.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
Do you believe that what he claims
holds any validity?

John is quiet, struggles genuinely for an answer.

Suddenly, a man in a suit enters the Interrogation Room,
followed by a woman.

MAN
This stops now. Now!

FEDERAL AGENT
Who the hell are you?

INT. INTERROGATION ROOM - CONTINUOUS

The man gets in between Raymond and the Federal Agent.

MAN
I'm Raymond Olsen's lawyer.
(gestures to woman)
This is Dr. Shephard, his
psychiatrist.

INT. OBSERVATION ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Captain, a sinking feeling...

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
Shit.

INT. INTERROGATION ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Raymond begins to cry. Dr. Shephard goes to him.

LAWYER
My client has not been evaluated.
Everything he just told you is
inadmissible.

Raymond, more upset, begins to wail. Dr. Shephard tries to
calm him. Raymond pushes Dr. Shephard away.

LAWYER (CONT'D)
You're monsters. Really. Monsters.
You know that?

FEDERAL AGENT
Hey. He volunteered to talk.

Raymond starts to thrash his head against the metal tabletop.
Over and over. Blood comes out.

DR. SHEPHARD
Raymond!

Officers subdue him. It's chaos.

INT. OBSERVATION ROOM - CONTINUOUS

John's had enough. He goes to leave. Captain stops him.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
I've issued an APB.

JOHN
I understand.

CAPTAIN MARCHAND
All due respect, John, just so
we're clear: you had your shot at
this. Let us handle Trudy.

JOHN
I'm sure you got your best men on
it.

John exits.

INT. HALLWAY - MOMENTS LATER

John walks briskly down the hallway. A rattled Doug
approaches with coffee.

DOUG
... John?

John hurries by.

JOHN
Relax, Doug. Everything's fine.

INT. JOHN'S CAR (DRIVING) - DAY

John driving Dover, seemingly without aim. He turns a corner
and is suddenly cut off by police barricades and a cop car
blocking the road, lights flashing.

John slows. Stops. Up ahead coming into view is...

A PARADE. The Dover Annual Santa Claus Parade. John takes a detour down a side road.

EXT. STREETS OF DOVER - DAY

The parade. Children, parents, the elderly in lawn chairs bundled up in blankets with their hot cocoa. Everyone a kid again. Anxious to glimpse the man himself, Santa.

EXT. CHURCH - DAY

Front steps of a church with a view of the street. John's car drives past and out of sight.

A squeal of car brakes. John's car reverses fast back into view and screeches to a halt.

See now what he sees -- Trudy's car. Tucked away in a corner of the church parking lot.

INT. CHURCH - DAY

John enters the church. Looks around. Just a couple nuns up front lighting candles. They leave. No sign of Trudy.

John dips his fingers into the holy water stoup, makes the sign of the cross. He starts down the aisle.

Somewhere the click of a door opening. John looks across to see a priest exiting a confessional booth. The priest sees John. The two share a look. The priest walks off.

EXT. CONFESSIONAL BOOTH - DAY

John approaches the booth. He opens it and slips inside.

INT. CONFESSIONAL BOOTH - CONTINUOUS

John sits in the priest's chair. A screen of lattice work separates him from the person kneeling on the other side.

It's Trudy. She looks to John, barely able to make eye contact. Through the screen John can see that she's nervous as hell. John looks about. He smiles.

JOHN

Little creepy sitting on this side.

(pause)

How many times as a kid I sat where
you're sitting? In this same booth.

Trudy, all bottled up, remains a million miles away.

JOHN (CONT'D)

Remember the bullshit we used to
spew in here? Not doing homework.
Saying curse words. Lying to mom
and dad.

(pause)

But the biggest sins were always
the ones we were too afraid to
admit.

Trudy looks across at John.

TRUDY

John. Have you ever criticized God?

John stays quiet, unsure what to say. Trudy confesses--

TRUDY (CONT'D)

I did. Twice. When mom died I had
my first doubts.

(pause)

And when I found out I couldn't
have children--

JOHN

I never should've gotten into that
boat.

TRUDY

What?

JOHN

I was piloting Andy's boat.

(beat)

Dad was supposed to take me to a
pitching clinic down in Boston. I
said I wanted to hang out with my
friends instead.

Trudy looks confused.

JOHN (CONT'D)

He was just trying to do what he
thought was right, but still... I
killed my best friend, Tru. And I
never had to answer for it.

A stunned Trudy. John watches her a moment. She seems torn.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Whatever happened we can figure it out. Together.

She looks to John, sees a knowledge in him.

TRUDY
How much does Doug know?

JOHN
He knows Dad and Reggie took matters into their own hands, but that they got the wrong guy.
(pause)
Just tell me you're not responsible for Holly's murder. Tell me a 45 year-old with Down Syndrome has it all wrong.

Trudy trembles. John slides the screen back. He takes her hands in his.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Look at me. Look at me, Tru.

She does, scared.

JOHN (CONT'D)
It might not hurt much right now. You might think you can get away with this. But wait twenty years, and you'll regret the day you walked into your own hell.

Trudy turns her head, wipes away a tear.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Did you kill Holly Roberts?

Trudy, tears running, emotions bottle-necked, utters quietly:

TRUDY
Yes.

Something in John had hoped she'd say "no". He slowly let's go of her.

Trudy takes a deep breath.

TRUDY (CONT'D)
I hired Raymond to take her. It was just for a few days.
(MORE)

TRUDY (CONT'D)
I wanted to teach Cheyenne a lesson. I wanted to show her how much she had to lose. Show her what it means not to have children. Then we'd let Holly go.

A FEW DAYS AGO...

EXT. THE BAY - SMALL BOAT - DAY

Way out on the bay in a small boat. The Dover coast in the distance. Trudy's at the helm.

TRUDY (V.O.)
When Dad got involved... I didn't know what to do. I was scared. I knew it wouldn't take long before they got to Raymond. I panicked.

Holly is on the boat. Hands bound. Blindfolded. She is clothed in crisp, white garments. She trembles.

TRUDY (V.O.)
So I got her back from Raymond.

The boat enters a thick fog bank. Trudy cuts the engine.

TRUDY (V.O.)
She was interested in the Church, in Jesus. Dad and I took her to Sunday school every week. I taught her the Bible. She took First Communion, and then Confirmation. Cheyenne wasn't happy about it. But Holly was excited. She was almost there. I was her Godmother.

Trudy holds a copy of the Bible in her hand. She leads a terrified Holly over to the edge of the boat.

TRUDY (V.O.)
All that was left was the baptism.

Holly struggles. Trudy forces Holly's head overboard.

INT. UNDERWATER - CONTINUOUS

As Holly's head is thrust down into the frigid waters of the bay. Held there. She writhes and struggles mightily.

INT. SMALL BOAT - CONTINUOUS

Trudy hauls Holly up. Holly cries as Trudy recites--

TRUDY

Praise to you, almighty God and
Father, for you have created water
to cleanse and to give new life.

She dunks Holly again. Holds her under. Holly flails.

TRUDY (CONT'D)

Father, look now with love upon
your Church, and unseal for her the
fountain of baptism...

Holly is lifted up again. She screams for help.

TRUDY (CONT'D)

... so that all who have been
buried with Christ by Baptism into
death may rise again to life with
Him, in the unity of the Holy
Spirit, one God, for ever and ever.
Amen.

Holly is forced back under. Close on Trudy's face, full of
fervor, as she recites her vows--

TRUDY (CONT'D)

Do you reject Satan and all his
works and all his empty promises?

(pause)

I do.

Holly is fighting back.

TRUDY (CONT'D)

Do you believe in God, the Father
almighty, creator of heaven and
earth?

(pause)

I do... Do you believe in Jesus
Christ, his only Son, our Lord? And
do you believe in the Holy Spirit--

Holly begins to overpower Trudy. Trudy strikes Holly across
her head. Repeatedly. She shoves her head deeper underwater.

TRUDY (CONT'D)
-- the holy Catholic Church, the
communion of saints, the
forgiveness of sins, the
resurrection of the body, and life
everlasting?

Holly stops struggling.

TRUDY (CONT'D)
... I do.

Trudy feels the resistance leave Holly. She let's go of her,
watches her, half overboard, bobbing lifelessly.

Trudy looks horrified.

THE PRESENT:

INT. CONFESSIONAL BOOTH - DAY

Trudy's expression matches the horror she felt on the boat.

TRUDY
I don't remember much after that.
Maybe I held her under for too
long. Maybe I hit her harder than I
thought I did. I -- I don't know.

John watches her. A long moment passes. Finally--

JOHN
Give me your keys.

Trudy looks up at John, wipes tears from her eyes.

TRUDY
What?

John digs into his pocket. He comes up with the keys to his
rental car. He holds them out to Trudy.

JOHN
Gimmie your car keys.

She doesn't understand.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Soon all of New England's gonna be
out looking for you. At least this
way you get a chance to think.

Trudy realizes. She takes out her car keys. Her and John make the exchange.

JOHN (CONT'D)
Rental's due back at the airport in
the morning.

TRUDY
What are you going to tell people?

JOHN
Nothing. It's between you and God
now.

John reaches in through the open partition. He kisses Trudy on the forehead. She holds him. He pulls away, looks at her--

JOHN (CONT'D)
Goodbye, Tru.

EXT. TRUDY'S CAR - MOMENTS LATER

John approaches Trudy's car. He unlocks it and climbs in. He starts it up and drives away.

EXT. TRUDY'S CAR - LATER

John stops at an intersection as the final leg of the Santa Claus parade rolls by.

A parade float passes carrying Santa's Workshop: elves making toys and the big man himself, Santa, sitting atop his sleigh. He waves at the parade-goers. He waves at John.

INT. TRUDY'S CAR - CONTINUOUS

John's POV: Holly's two friends, Beth and Krista, are aboard the Santa float, dressed as elves and holding their hobbyhorses.

John watches them, their expressions -- the illusion of safety and innocence ripped from them forever.

EXT. SUBURBAN HOME - LATER

John pulls into the driveway of a well-kept bungalow.

INT. TRUDY'S CAR - CONTINUOUS

John, car idling, stares out at the home. He shuts off the car and climbs out.

INT. ANDY'S PARENTS HOME - MOMENTS LATER

A doorbell chimes. A woman appears (60's). She opens the door to see John standing here on the stoop.

JOHN
Hello, Mrs. Murphy.

MRS. MURPHY pauses. Her eyes narrow at John. Then it clicks--

MRS. MURPHY
Johnny? Johnny Kierstead? My God.

MR. MURPHY appears behind his wife. These are Andy's parents. John stays on the stoop, looking hesitant.

The Murphy's look John in the eyes, trying to read him.

MR. MURPHY
Would you like to come inside,
John?

JOHN
Mr. Murphy, Mrs. Murphy... um...
(pause, deep breath)
There's something I have to tell
you.

THE END